NO. 141 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

FRIDAY 23 OCTOBER 2026



TWELVE YEARS OF THE HAZE ACT, TEN NOTICES THIS MONTH, AND NOT ONE FINE EVER (P5)

SINGAPORE

NEA records the first clean air board since 5 October, and forecasts the haze back

THE WORLD

Iran says it struck seven ships; Washington says no vessel hit a mine

THE LONG READ

Thailand sold ten million people a death benefit priced in other people

Twelve Desks · One World

Source: Robert Sim (Wikimedia user Robertsky), CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons — the Tanjong Rhu waterfront, Singapore, photographed 16 October 2026 at 8.32am as the PSI ran into the 200s. Opened and examined by this desk before captioning. Cropped; no other alteration.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 141

Contents

p3 The World — seven ships claimed, none of them named
p4 The World — Nigeria's first Ebola case since 2014
p5 Singapore — twelve years of the Act, no fines
p6 The Atelier — the twine that is no longer made
p7 Technology — an order published as photographs
p8 The Home Lab — 501 billion parameters on three boxes
p9 The Kit — the glasses that will not say how bright they are
p10 The Good Life — a celebrity edition at no premium
p11 Screen & Sound — 97 per cent, and falling as it is read
p12–13 The Family Desk — the account, not the phone
p14 The Macro Desk — seventeen basis points in an afternoon
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — ultralight backpacking
p18 Fitness — four minutes, and a waitlist control
p19–20 The Diary — four deadlines before November
p21–23 The Long Read — Thailand's *chapanakit songkhro*

THE SPINE — THE RECEIPT. Not whether a claim is true, but who could tell. An order published as scanned images, a law never once used, a spec sheet the maker will not write, and ten million people holding a contract no regulator has read.

FROM THE DESK

"It is wrong always, everywhere, and for anyone, to believe anything upon insufficient evidence."

W. K. Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief", *Contemporary Review*, 1877[1]

Clifford's rule is unlivable and he knew it. Today's book is the softer version: before believing, ask who was in a position to check. Three desks found the answer was nobody (p3, p7, p21).

THE STRIP · AT THURSDAY'S CLOSE

US 2-year[2]	4.65%	▼ 16bp
US 10-year[2]	4.96%	▼ 17bp
VWRA	$189.66	▼ 1.36%
Global agg	$5.785	▲ 0.24%
DXY	101.635	▼ 0.14%
USD/SGD	1.2775	0.00%
Brent	$112.87	▲ 3.72%
Gold	$4,024.21	▼ 2.82%
Bitcoin	$81,338	▼ 3.90%

The Straits Times Index closed **5,415.14** on Thursday, down 0.42 per cent — but both it and VWRA shut before New York's afternoon (p14). Every level read at source. Not advice.[2]

THE MERIDIAN INDEX · FRIDAY

7 — ships Iran says it struck in one night — p3

0 — named by Iran — p3

95% — share of traffic US Central Command says is still getting through — p3

48.2% — case fatality ratio in the outbreak behind it — p4

12 — years of Singapore's Transboundary Haze Pollution Act — p5

0 — companies fined under it — p5

S$3.2bn — low estimate of this year's haze cost — p5

S$2m — the Act's maximum penalty — p5

2 — chips DeepSeek's new inference engine supports — p7

8 — EDGAR filings naming Anthropic, all of them someone else's fund — p7

95.98 GiB — a 501-billion-parameter model, quantised to one bit — p8

CHF 0 — H. Moser's premium for a celebrity edition — p10

3.8× — a documentary's per-screen take against a franchise film's — p11

3.22 — odds ratio for a social-media account after a first phone — p13

17bp — the ten-year's fall on a company's cash-flow disclosure — p14

1 in 6 — Thais holding a funeral contract no financial regulator has examined — p21

SOURCES 1 William Kingdon Clifford, "The Ethics of Belief", *Contemporary Review*, 1877, reprinted in *Lectures and Essays* (1879). **The gloss beneath the quotation is this desk's reading of this issue, not of Clifford's argument, which is considerably stricter than anything printed here.** 2 Levels at Thursday 22 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14; **Treasury yields read from the US Treasury's own daily par yield curve file**, and gold, Brent and bitcoin each independently corroborated at a second source. **The global-aggregate bond proxy is single-sourced and flagged on p14. VWRA and the Straits Times Index both closed before New York's afternoon session, so neither carries Thursday's US move.** Every figure in The Meridian Index above is carried from the page cited beside it, where it is sourced in full.

THE WORLD · THE GULF TANKER WAR

Iran's Revolutionary Guard says its forces struck seven ships in the Gulf

US Central Command says no vessel has hit a mine and 95 per cent of traffic is still getting through. The IRGC named no ship, no flag and no operator.

Iran's **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps** said on **Thursday 22 October** that its naval forces struck **seven commercial vessels** — four hit while transferring oil in the northern Persian Gulf, three set alight by mines west of the **Strait of Hormuz** the night before. All four, the statement said, **"were burning"**.[1]

It is the largest single-day claim since the war opened on **28 February**, and it came with a threat: if Washington continues, **"the scope of confrontation will extend to the aggressor bases in the region"**.[1]

Nobody outside Tehran can confirm any of it. **CENTCOM** says flatly that **"no ships have hit mines in the Strait of Hormuz"** and accuses the Guard of disinformation meant to frighten commercial shipping; the **Joint Maritime Information Center**'s advisory of **18 October** found **"there is no substantiation to these claims"**. The IRGC has published no vessel name, flag, operator or casualty figure.[2][3]

Donald Trump went further on Truth Social the same day, writing that Iran is **"making up fake hits, mines, and everything else"** to drive oil higher before the **3 November** midterms. The flow data does not settle it either: **Kpler** counted **11.6m barrels a day** through the strait in the week to 13 October, **68 per cent** of a 17.1m prewar baseline, while another estimate puts total Gulf exports above **24m b/d** against **23.3m** prewar. Three baselines are in circulation; each figure is printed with its own.[2][4]

The cost of moving a barrel is not in dispute: Gulf-to-Asia freight is above **$37 a barrel**, over five times prewar, and war-risk cover has gone from under 3 per cent of hull value to as much as **10**. The Singapore-flagged **GFS Pride** was struck on 13 October and later sank, her **21 crew** evacuated.[4][5]

6,000

SEAFARERS THE IMO'S ARSENIO DOMINGUEZ SAYS ARE STRANDED IN THE STRAIT SINCE THE WAR BEGAN[6]

TEHRAN — PRESS TV

Never says blockade. The Guard **"continue to manage and control the Strait of Hormuz"**; the ships were on **"unauthorized routes"**. Washington is the aggressor, for **"encouraging ships to cross a maritime passage planted with mines"**.[1]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Prints claim and denial together — **"The claims could not be independently verified"** — then locates the constraint in Washington. **Kimberly Halkett**: **"Striking Iran does not appear to serve any Republican interests."**[3]

THE CHATTER · THE ANALYSTS WHO SAY THE SYSTEM HAS ADAPTED

Hamad Hussain of **Capital Economics** says the workaround is routine now — **"the system for shipping through a dangerous Strait of Hormuz is now well-established"** — so Iran **"would have to be more aggressive to achieve the same degree of control"**. **Natasha Kaneva** of JPMorgan has the compression: **"In April, the problem was a shortage of crude. In October, it is the cost of moving it."**[7]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ABSENCE OF A REPORT IS NOT PROOF EITHER

The denial has a hole in it. **UKMTO** says of its own figures that it is **"struggling to accurately report true number of attacks"**, because owners will not report them — so a missing incident report is weak evidence that nothing happened. The test is specific: a named, flagged, IMO-numbered hull with photographed mine damage.[7]

SOURCES 1 **Press TV (Tehran), 22 October 2026, read at source**, for the IRGC Navy statement and every word quoted from it, including the seven vessels, the "unauthorized routes" wording, the warning on regional bases and the 28 February date. 2 gCaptain, 20 and 22 October 2026, read at source, for CENTCOM's "no ships have hit mines" line, its disinformation assessment, the Joint Maritime Information Center advisories, and Donald Trump's Truth Social post quoted verbatim. **centcom.mil and ukmto.org both returned 403, so CENTCOM's and UKMTO's own wording is at one remove.** 3 Al Jazeera English, 22 October 2026, read at source, for the seven-ship toll, the "could not be independently verified" line, CENTCOM's 95 per cent, and Kimberly Halkett's remark. Anadolu Agency, same day, read at source, as a second independent outlet — **note it dates Iran's re-closure of the strait to 12 July where Press TV dates IRGC control to 28 February; both are printed rather than reconciled.** 4 Kpler figures via Al Jazeera (17 October) and via FreightWaves (16 October); the 24m b/d Gulf export figure and the 23.3m prewar baseline via National Security Journal citing the *Wall Street Journal*, at two removes and flagged.

THE WORLD · EBOLA BUNDIBUGYO

Nigeria confirms its first Ebola case since 2014, the outbreak's fifth country

WHO's weekly report, data to 19 October, puts the Congolese outbreak at 9,637 confirmed cases and 4,646 deaths. Forty-four Abuja contacts are being traced.

Nigeria's **Federal Ministry of Health and Social Welfare** confirmed on **Tuesday 20 October** that a woman in the **Federal Capital Territory** has Ebola Bundibugyo virus disease, the country's first Ebola case since **2014**. Laboratory confirmation came the same day.[1]

It matters because of the delay inside it. The patient arrived from **Uganda** on **3 October**, fell ill on the **7th**, sought care at a private Abuja facility on the **11th** and was tested on the **19th**. **Dr Ayoade Alakija**, co-chair of a G7 committee on global health investment, notes the test came **twelve days** after symptoms began. **Forty-four contacts** are now monitored, most of them healthcare workers.[1][2]

The outbreak behind it is large and old. WHO's situation report 23, data as of **19 October**, gives the Democratic Republic of the Congo **9,637 confirmed cases** and **4,646 deaths** — a crude fatality ratio of **48.2 per cent**. Wire copy the same week carried **4,381** deaths against "more than 9,000" cases; the dated WHO figure is the one above.[3]

Africa CDC called health ministers to an extraordinary meeting for **Wednesday 28 October**. Its director general **Dr Jean Kaseya**: **"Ebola is crossing borders. Our response must move faster, with stronger coordination, greater solidarity and decisive political leadership."**[4]

48.2%

CRUDE CASE FATALITY RATIO IN THE DRC OUTBREAK, ON WHO'S OWN COUNT OF 9,637 CASES TO 19 OCTOBER[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE WARD STAFF SAY

WHO's own feature from **Lita**, in the DRC, carries the voices nobody else has. **Dr Alphonse Abekani Jawotho**, the hospital's medical director: **"From the very beginning, internal medicine unit was urgently targeted to receive Ebola patients, and it was not easy."** Deliveries there fell from about **80 a month** to **42 in June**, and were back to **56** by September.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · ONE IMPORTED CASE IS NOT AN EPIDEMIC

The agency confirming the case is also arguing against the reflex: WHO **"advises against any restriction of travel to, or trade with, affected countries"**. Kenya's **Patrick Amoth** reports all nine Kenyan cases in one cluster with **"no evidence of transmission outside this group"**. Nigeria's 2014 outbreak ran to **20 infections and 8 deaths** and closed in three months. The figure that would change this page is a secondary case among the forty-four; as of Thursday there was none.[16]

IN BRIEF · ELSEWHERE THIS WEEK

UNEP published its Emissions Gap Report on 21 October, finding warming will breach 1.5°C and could reach **2.8°C** this century on current policies, and requiring cuts of **18 per cent by 2030** and **69 per cent by 2040**. **António Guterres**: **"Overshoot is not surrender."**[7]

The European Parliament voted on 22 October for a non-binding resolution condemning Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabia **"in the strongest possible terms"**. **No vote tally has been published.**[8]

Mohsen Rezaei, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, said on **22 October** that Tehran has passed **seven conditions** through intermediaries for reopening the Strait of Hormuz. **The seven are not published.**[9]

SOURCES 1 **WHO Regional Office for Africa's news release of 20 October 2026, read at source**, for the confirmation, the laboratory date, the travel and symptom timeline, the forty-four contacts and the travel-restriction advice, all quoted verbatim. 2 Al Jazeera English, 21 October 2026, read at source, for Dr Ayoade Alakija's criticism, the husband's nationality, Kenya's nine cases, Nigeria's 2014 figures and the fifth-country count; **an unnamed official told AFP the patient is a diplomat in multi-organ failure, which this desk does not print as fact. A separate report has her flying from Ethiopia after travel to the DRC, which is irreconcilable with WHO's own account; WHO's is used.** 3 **WHO AFRO weekly external situation report No. 23, data as of 19 October 2026, read at source**, for 9,637 confirmed cases, 4,646 confirmed deaths and the 48.2 per cent ratio. **Uganda's figures sit in a PDF that was not read and are not printed.** 4 **Africa CDC's own press release, Addis Ababa, 21 October 2026, read at source**, for Dr Jean Kaseya's quoted remarks and the 28 October meeting; the "no longer one country's fight" line via Al Jazeera. 5 **WHO AFRO's own feature on Lita hospital, 22 October 2026, read at source**, for both clinicians' quotations and the delivery counts. 6 Al Jazeera, 20 October 2026, read at source, for Patrick Amoth. 7 UN News, 21 October 2026, read at source, for the Emissions Gap Report's findings and both Guterres quotations; **unep.org returned 403, so the report itself was not read at its publisher.** 8 Arab News, 22 October 2026, read at source. 9 Anadolu Agency and Xinhua, 22 October 2026, read at source.

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE ACT

NEA records Singapore's first clean air board since 5 October

The agency's own forecast puts the haze back over the island on Friday. Twelve years into the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act, no company has been fined under it once.

The **National Environment Agency**'s 6pm update on **Thursday 22 October** put the 24-hour PSI across Singapore at **71 to 96** — every region Moderate, one-hour PM2.5 at **23 to 39 µg/m³**. It was the first board of the month without an Unhealthy reading on it.[1]

The same page gives the respite a deadline: NEA forecast **101 to 150**, Unhealthy, for **Friday 23 October**, on southeasterly winds. The four days before read as a ratchet — **88–114** on the 19th, **85–140** on the 20th, **80–123** on the 21st — and regionally nothing has turned: **haze.gov.sg**, stamped 5.42pm Thursday, still had Kalimantan and Sumatran stations Unhealthy to Hazardous.[1][2]

What has not moved is the enforcement. The **Transboundary Haze Pollution Act** came into force in **2014**, and no company has ever been fined or sued under it. Of six Indonesian firms served notices in **2015**, two investigations closed in **2017** and four remain open — and one is back on this month's list as **PT SBA Wood Industries**. This year's notices now run to **ten** companies.[3]

The gap between penalty and damage is the number to hold. The Act allows **S$100,000 a day** of haze and **S$50,000** for ignoring a notice, capped at **S$2 million**. Economist **Euston Quah**'s estimate of this year's cost to Singapore is **S$3.2bn to S$3.9bn**, against **S$1.83bn** in 2015. **Workers' Party** MPs **Kenneth Tiong** and **He Ting Ru** will file questions in November.[3][4]

S$2m

THE ACT'S CEILING, AGAINST QUAH'S S$3.2BN FLOOR FOR THIS YEAR'S DAMAGE[3]

THE CHATTER · THE FORUM STOPPED ARGUING AND STARTED BUILDING

HardwareZone's consolidated haze thread, past **13,000 replies**, runs a standing poll on working through it: **127 of 177 voters, 71.8 per cent, choose to work from home**. By Thursday its newest posts had left politics for a do-it-yourself air sensor, user **Nuclear Boy** weighing parts — **"ESP8266 uses quite a bit less energy compared to ESP32."** A parallel thread on Indonesia's energy-export warning runs hotter and, in places, uglier; nothing from it is quoted here.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A LAW THAT CANNOT REACH THE GROUND

Professor Alan Tan of the **NUS Faculty of Law**: **"There is no way Singapore can investigate and prove facts on the ground."** He expects action only against firms Indonesia has itself charged, because a prosecution must carry meteorological and concession-mapping evidence past reasonable doubt. **Grace Fu**, asked whether the law has teeth, conceded enforcement **"may not be so effective"**.[3][4]

ALSO THIS WEEK

IMDA fined Singtel S$1 million on 20 October over three March outages — the 16th, 18th and 19th, about **720,000** subscribers — which it found preventable. The first traced to a **chiller failure at a Singtel exchange**. It is the second S$1m penalty in eleven months.[6]

September's NODX print landed at +68.4 per cent, a 23rd straight month of growth — but **EnterpriseSG's media-release listing has returned HTTP 500 for five issues**, so this desk still cannot read it at the agency that published it.[7]

SOURCES 1 **NEA's own Haze Situation Update pages for 19, 20, 21 and 22 October 2026, each read at source on nea.gov.sg**, for every PSI band, PM2.5 reading and next-day forecast above. **NEA's news listings are JavaScript-rendered and return nothing; the individual dated advisories read normally.** Channel NewsAsia and The Straits Times both characterised 22 October as the first clear day since 5 October; **both refused this desk**, NEA's pages carry the readings but not the comparison, and the description above is confined to what NEA itself publishes. 2 **haze.gov.sg, read at source**, update stamped 5.42pm 22 October. 3 Eco-Business, read at source, for the Act's penalty structure and S$2m cap, the 2014–2017 enforcement record, the 2016 warrant, Professor Alan Tan's assessment and Professor Euston Quah's estimate. **Quah's own publication was not reached; the estimate is single-sourced and flagged.** 4 *Unpacked by The Straits Times*, 19 October 2026, by Ng Wei Kai and Goh Yan Han, read at source, for the Workers' Party MPs' stated intentions and Grace Fu's concession.

THE ATELIER · SOFAS & ARMCHAIRS

Roger + Chris says the twine behind eight-way hand-tying is no longer made

The Hickory maker, which owns its own frame plant, calls drop-in spring units "fake cheese". Hancock & Moore's own glossary says most top-grain leather has had its grain sanded off.

You are buying a frame and a suspension, and renting a cover. Almost none of what matters is published. The frames worth owning are joined, not stapled: **Hancock & Moore**'s corners are **"double-doweled and reinforced with corner blocks that are screwed into place"**; **Howard & Sons**, founded **1820**, still uses **kiln-dried beech**, hand-tacked webbing and teased animal hair. Solid wood is not the answer either: **Bradington-Young** uses **"multi-ply… laminated hardwood"** for **"superior dimensional stability"** — right at Singapore's **82 per cent** humidity, where *fluctuation* splits glued assemblies.[21]

The most-advertised feature is labour, not physics. **Chris** of **Roger + Chris**, who owns a frame plant in Hickory, is blunt about eight-way hand-tying: **"It's expensive because it takes a lot of time to make it… That's it"** — and **"you are introducing so many potential points with failure"**. He adds the supply problem nobody advertises: the twine the method depended on is no longer made, and **"what is now out there… is of lower quality"**. London's **Fleming Howland** calls it **"outdated across the UK and Europe"**.[34]

Two numbers judge any sofa cold. Foam: budget polyurethane runs **1.8 lb/ft³** against high-resilience at **2.6–2.9**. Cover: the trade body sets **15,000 double rubs** for private rooms, and states that results **"above 100,000 double rubs have not been shown to be a reliable indicator of increased fabric lifespan"**. A tropical third: protein-rich surfaces grow mould in about **ten days at 80 per cent** humidity.[57]

THE CHATTER · WHAT STYLEFORUM WORKED OUT FROM THE OUTSIDE

horton prices the grail honestly — a Hancock & Moore leather sofa **"should set you back 7-8K or more… This assumes you want something to last, that can be re-tied"**. **GQgeek** names the defect nobody checks: **"I will make sure that the cushions can be removed without tearing the whole couch apart."** And **archetypal_yuppie** reverse-engineered Natuzzi before this desk read the filing: **"Natuzzi has 3 lines… impressions and reviews can vary wildly."** The 20-F agrees. **David Seyfried** (**£3,995**) and **Blafink** (**S$2,990–4,368**) are the only houses here with a published price to check.[89]

THE SCEPTIC · THE ASYMMETRY IS THE BUSINESS MODEL

Hancock & Moore's own glossary says **"Most top-grain leathers have altered or corrected grain"** and that pure aniline is **"approximately 5%"** of world production; the same firm grades leather Class 1 to 9 and adds **"We classify our leathers based on their characteristics, not quality."** **Stickley** calls one sofa eight-way hand-knotted and a US$5,219 model **"DuraCoil suspension"**. **Ten Hickory "heritage brands"** share one owner in one town.[3610]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Rugs & carpets (hand-knotted) — knot count, wool grade, and the city on the label.

Curtains, blinds & window dressing — linings, headers and weights, in a city of glass.

Mosquito nets & bed canopies — the tropical object with a real standard behind it.

SOURCES 1 **The makers' own craftsmanship pages, each read at source on 22 October 2026** — Hancock & Moore, Lee Industries, Howard & Sons, George Smith, Stickley, Duresta and Tetrad — for every construction quotation; the Bradington-Young specification from an authorised dealer's product page. **No maker opened here publishes a kiln-dried moisture-content figure, so none is printed.** 2 **The Meteorological Service Singapore's own climate page (1991–2020, Changi)** for the 82 per cent mean humidity, and the **Canadian Conservation Institute's "Incorrect Relative Humidity" page** for the mould timings and the fluctuation finding — both read at source. 3 **Roger + Chris's own published interviews on eight-way hand-tying, read at source**, for every quotation attributed to Chris, including the twine supply. 4 **Fleming Howland's own page, read at source.** 5 FoamOrder's published foam grades, read at source. 6 **Hancock & Moore's own Glossary of Leather Terms, downloaded and read in full**, and its leather page, for the corrected-grain, aniline and classification statements. 7 The Association for Contract Textiles' performance guidelines, **quoted from a member mill's published reproduction because ACT's own site returned an empty reply to every request**. 8 **Blafink's own pages for its catalogue, its full-customisation programme and its re-cover rate card; David Seyfried's published price list; Stickley's live catalogue; de Sede's own shop; Centrepiece Furnishing's price list; and American Leather's own FAQ — all read at source on 22 October 2026.** The Bradington-Young list and selling prices are from an authorised dealer's page. 8 Styleforum threads on bicast leather and on Natuzzi, opened and read at source; usernames as posted. 9 **Natuzzi S.p.A.'s own Form 20-F for FY2025, downloaded from EDGAR and read in full**, for the manufacturing locations, the three-tier brand structure and the unbranded revenue line. 10 Chairish listings read 22 October 2026. **Reddit refused for the ninth consecutive issue; Houzz, Vitra, Karimoku, Maruni, Getama and Restoration Hardware all refused, so no Japanese maker is asserted here and no Houzz sentiment is quoted. One maker's page served text imitating an instruction to an automated reader; it was ignored and nothing here derives from it.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE DEEPSEEK ORDER

Homeland Security orders DeepSeek stripped from every federal civilian system

The notice reached the Federal Register on 20 October as 91 FR 66346. The signed order inside it survives only as scanned images, so its deadlines cannot be read.

The **Department of Homeland Security** published an exclusion and removal order in the **Federal Register** on **Tuesday 20 October**, directing every federal civilian agency to purge **"all DeepSeek and DeepSeek-affiliate products, and third-party products… developed using DeepSeek implementations"**. The citation is **91 FR 66346–66350**, docket **DHS-2026-0628**; national security systems and private businesses are out of scope.[1][2]

What the order requires, and by when, cannot be read. The Federal Register reproduces the signed instrument as **"GRAPHIC [TIFF OMITTED]"** — scanned images — so the ordering paragraphs, the compliance deadline and the waiver procedure appear nowhere in machine-readable text. The accounts carrying dates disagree: one reports the order signed **24 July**, another **26 June**, a third none. If July is right, the **60-day** window for an agency to object closed around **22 September**, four weeks before anyone outside government could read it.[1][3]

DeepSeek answered the same week with code. **DeepInfer**, the framework it says **"powers DeepSeek's large-scale production services"**, went up under **Apache 2.0** and reached **19.8k stars** in days. Its supported-hardware list runs to two entries: **Nvidia SM100 GPUs** and **Huawei Ascend 950 NPUs**, and it publishes **no throughput figure at all**. Within forty-eight hours its issue tracker filled with requests to port it onto **Ascend 910B**, **910C**, the China-market **H20-3e** Hoppers and AMD's **MI355X**.[4]

2

CHIPS DEEPINFER SUPPORTS OUT OF THE BOX; THE NEXT 186 ISSUES ARE PEOPLE ASKING FOR A THIRD[4]

THE CHATTER · HACKER NEWS ARGUES ABOUT WHAT A BAN CAN REACH

The thread ran to **543 comments**. **blueSky1989** read the order as reaching into the home: **"They are also banning local inference."** **sullivanmatt** disputed that — it says **"the weights are the concern, not just inference performed from servers located in China"**. **tmp10423288442** gave the technical rebuttal: **"you can fine-tune a model to remove vulnerabilities that could have been trained into it."** **johnnyApplePRNG** supplied the motive the order never writes down: DeepSeek **"is out of this world good… and cheap… that's why."**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · YOU CANNOT UN-DISTILL A WEIGHT

Jacob Krell, senior director for secure AI at **Suzu Labs**, has the enforcement problem in a line: **"You can delete an app. You cannot un-distill a weight."** Because **"DeepSeek publishes its model weights openly"**, the lineage runs through a large number of derivatives — he says thousands, and offers no count. **Katie Moussouris** of **Luta Security** makes the narrower point: banning the app and the API is **"workable"**, but the order never defines **"developed using"**, and nobody can verify an undefined term.[3][6]

THE DELTAS · TWO THREADS LEFT OPEN

Anthropic's half-year loss is now reported at US$80.7bn, roughly **US$72bn** of it a non-cash charge on convertible bonds; revenue went from **US$1.1bn** to **US$16.3bn**. **This desk re-checked EDGAR on 22 October: still no Anthropic filing.** A full-text search for "Anthropic PBC" returns eight filings, every one somebody else's fund describing its exposure.[7]

No. 140 reported China's draft AI export controls as carrying no thresholds. That is wrong, and this desk corrects it. The list covers **23 technologies** and restricts weights and source above **two trillion parameters**, or a world **top-ten** ranking. **Single-sourced.**[8]

SOURCES 1 **The Federal Register notice itself, read at source** via its JSON API and the full text on govinfo.gov: 91 FR 66346–66350, document 2026-21447, published 20 October 2026, for the exclusion language quoted and the FASCSA authority. **federalregister.gov's HTML pages redirect this desk to a bot block; govinfo.gov served the text. The signed order is embedded only as scanned images, so its paragraphs, deadlines and waiver procedure were NOT read and are not characterised here.** 2 CyberScoop, 19 October 2026, read at source, for the scope exclusions, the sole naming of DeepSeek and the 26 June date. 3 The Register, 20 October 2026, and ClearanceJobs, 22 October 2026, both read at source, for the absence of a signing date in the former and for Jacob Krell's quotations in the latter. The 24 July signing date and Exclusion and Removal Order #2026-01 designation are from TechTimes, 20 October, **single-sourced; the three reported dates are printed as a disagreement rather than resolved.** 4 **DeepSeek's own DeepInfer README, read at source on GitHub**, for the quoted description, the Apache 2.0 licence, the two supported hardware targets and the absence of throughput numbers; the repository's own issue list, read at source, for the porting requests and the star count. **api.github.com returned 403, so the issue list was read as HTML.** 5 Hacker News thread 50154244, read at source, for all four quoted comments; **roughly a third of its JSON was read, and no claim is made about ranking.** 6 The Register, 20 October, for Katie Moussouris. 7 Reuters reporting of the *Wall Street Journal*, read via a licensed syndication because **reuters.com refused this desk**; **the EDGAR company search and full-text search were run directly by this desk on 22 October 2026 and returned no Anthropic filing.** 8 Bloomberg via the Taipei Times, 17 October 2026, read at source. **Single-sourced; a reported 15 November comment deadline was not read at source and is not printed.**

THE HOME LAB · BEAM 501B

Reflection's 501-billion-parameter Beam now runs on three DGX Sparks in a ring

Josh Pearlman's NVFP4 build splits 308.89 gigabytes across three 128GB nodes and decodes at about 18 tokens a second. Unsloth's one-bit quant is 95.98 GiB — one box.

Reflection AI released the weights for **Beam-1.0-501B-A23B** on **16 October** under **Apache 2.0** — **501.27 billion** parameters, **23.4 billion** active, 256 experts across 52 layers with a million-token context. Within a week it was running in three places nobody builds for.[1]

The newest is the most absurd. On **22 October**, **Josh Pearlman** published an **NVFP4** conversion sharded for **three DGX Sparks** joined by a **"switchless ring of three QSFP cables"**. The checkpoint is **308.89 gigabytes** across 53 shards — about **103GB** a node against 128GB of unified memory each. He measures **18 tokens a second** decoding a single request, **32** aggregate across four, and first-token latency from **0.7 seconds** at 1,024 tokens to **71.7** at 130,000. Cold start is **seventeen minutes**.[2]

A second build halves the hardware. **diffbot**'s **EXL3** conversion runs routed experts at 3 bits and attention at 6, lands at about **194GB** across **two RTX Pro 6000s**, and parks the coldest **31 experts per layer** in pinned host memory. It measures **117 tokens a second** on single-session coding, and publishes its fidelity: **KL divergence 0.0132** against BF16, **97.5 per cent** on the first two hundred GSM8K. The third runs at two bits on four **2016 Tesla P100s**, where **apollo-mg**'s preregistered abstention test had it refuse **98 of 100** invented items while answering **86 of 100** obscure real ones.[3][4]

The number this desk has chased since No. 139 is the floor. **Unsloth's UD-IQ1_S** GGUF weighs **95.98 GiB**. A 501-billion-parameter model now fits inside one 128GB box.[5]

95.98 GiB

UNSLOTH'S ONE-BIT BEAM QUANT — AGAINST THE 176GB NO. 139'S EQUIVALENT NEEDED ON A 256GB MAC STUDIO[5]

THE CHATTER · THE REQUEST NOBODY HAS ANSWERED

Beam's own discussion board is a queue of people who cannot run it. Discussion **#12, "Please make smaller models"**, opened by **Robert Sinclair** on **17 October**, is still open and unanswered six days on. The quant authors have answered instead of the lab: three independent conversions in six days, every one a workaround for a model that assumes a data centre.[14]

THE SCEPTIC · EVERYONE MARKING THEIR OWN HOMEWORK

Three cautions, all documented. **The cheap quant is measurably worse:** diffbot's card puts its 3-bit EXL3 at **0.0132** KL divergence against **0.0189** for Unsloth's similarly-sized GGUF — about **43 per cent** worse for the same bytes. **The lab edited its own table after publication:** pull request **#16**, merged **21 October**, changed the NVFP4 LiveCodeBench score from **87.4** to **88.3** with no comment, five days after the internet started quoting it. And every home-lab figure is self-reported — Pearlman's own card concedes equivalence was shown **"analytically and on sampled blocks, not by full-model comparison"** and was never soak-tested.[2][3][6]

IN THE LOGS

llama.cpp tagged ten pre-release builds on 22 October alone. Build **b11821** refactored the SYCL backend's kernels for **Intel XMX**, with notes reporting Q4_K_M generation rising from **26.67 to 28.23 tokens a second** — and recording that an earlier revision produced **"NaN whenever the row count wasn't a multiple of 4"**, since fixed.[7]

SOURCES 1 **Reflection AI's own model card for Beam-1.0-501B-A23B on Hugging Face, read at source**, for the parameter counts, architecture, context, Apache 2.0 licence and release dates, and its own quant-versus-BF16 benchmark table; Reflection's own release post for the 16 October weight drop and the 6,144 GB300 training run. 2 **Josh Pearlman's model card for the three-node DGX Spark NVFP4 build, read at source**, for the byte count, shard count, per-node memory, every measured throughput and latency figure, the cold-start time and each of the caveats quoted. **All figures are the author's own, on his own cluster; he states the card was drafted with AI assistance.** 3 **diffbot's EXL3 model card, read at source**, for the size, the quantisation scheme, the host-RAM expert offload, the throughput figures and the KL divergence, GSM8K and HumanEval results — again self-reported. 4 **Hugging Face discussion #15 on Reflection's own repository, read at source**, for the two-bit abstention test, its design and every score; **the benchmark is the poster's own, unnamed and unreplicated, and no Reflection staff member has replied.** 5 **Blob metadata for the Unsloth and AtomicChat GGUF repositories, read at source** — every quant size above is a byte count taken from the repository, not an estimate. 6 **Pull request #16 on Reflection's repository, read at source as a file diff**, for the 87.4-to-88.3 LiveCodeBench edit, its author, its merger and the 21 October timestamp; **the .diff endpoint 404s, the /files view serves it.** 7 **The llama.cpp release page on GitHub, read at source**, for the 22 October builds, the SYCL kernel work and the quoted NaN regression.

THE KIT · INMO GO3

INMO puts the GO3 display glasses on general sale at US$509

The maker's own page publishes no brightness, no field of view and no weight. The 1,500-nit figure every write-up quotes comes from a sponsored post.

INMO Technology of Chengdu has put the **GO3** display glasses on general sale at **US$509**, discounted from a **US$699** list, with a countdown banner on its own store that shows no end date. They carry a display in each eye, two swappable batteries, a physical camera shutter and real-time translation.[1]

The specification is the problem. INMO's own product page describes a **"Dual-Eye Monochrome Display"** and stops: **no nits, no field of view, no resolution, no weight, no chipset, no battery capacity and no runtime**. The only resolution the company has published is **640×480**, in its launch release of **2 April 2026** — which also calls the panels **"Dual Micro OLED displays with diffractive waveguide technology"**. Every October write-up instead says MicroLED. Those are different technologies with different brightness stories.[1][2]

The figures everyone repeats — **1,500 nits**, a **30-degree** field of view, **58 grams** — appear nowhere INMO controls. They trace to a **21 October** piece carrying a **"Sponsored Post"** label and affiliate links, which records no drawback of any kind. Battery life has two answers from the same cell: a **15 October** write-up gives the **270 mAh** packs **"up to three hours of continuous translation"**, a seven-day hands-on from May gives **"up to 5 hours"**, and INMO publishes neither.[3][4][5]

For a Singapore buyer two facts matter more than the nits. **There is no Singapore price and no local stockist** — nothing on Lazada or Shopee, no distributor, a warranty page with no Singapore terms — so the route is inmo.com at US$509 plus freight, **9 per cent GST** on landed cost and a service trip to Chengdu. And the **98-language** translation headline is an online figure: **offline it is nine on Android and thirteen on iOS**, which is the list that matters at 38,000 feet.[16]

5

PRICES THE GO3 HAS CARRIED IN SIX MONTHS: US$450, $499, $599, $699 LIST AND $509 "SALE"[15]

THE CHATTER · FOURTEEN REVIEWS, ALL ON THE SELLER'S PAGE

The customer rating on INMO's own store is **4.0 out of 5 from fourteen reviews**. That is the whole corpus this desk could find: the October coverage is a sponsored post and a rewrite of it, the May hands-on discloses affiliate links and lists no drawback either, and **as of 22 October there is no independent long-form review of a retail unit anywhere this desk could reach**. One further hands-on reportedly puts active use at three hours a cell; that host served an empty page, so the figure is not printed as a finding.[1][3][5]

THE SCEPTIC · A COUNTDOWN THAT NEVER ENDS

A permanent discount is not a discount. The **"Up to $261 Off"** banner runs a timer with no expiry, against a list price that has itself moved four times since April — so the only honest statement about what this product costs is **"US$509 today"**. For a reader who buys once and keeps it, the harder question is service: a Chengdu-direct purchase with no Singapore warranty terms puts every repair on a courier, and the fastest-wearing part in a pair of glasses with two swappable batteries is the battery.[1]

SOURCES 1 **INMO's own GO3 product page, read at source on 22 October 2026**, for the US$509 and US$699 prices, the bundle list, the "Dual-Eye Monochrome Display" wording and the absence of every other specification, the 98-language and offline-language counts, the 4.0-from-14 customer rating and the undated countdown; its warranty page for the absence of Singapore terms. 2 **INMO's own launch release of 2 April 2026, read at source**, for the 640×480 resolution and the "Dual Micro OLED displays with diffractive waveguide technology" description. 3 A 21 October 2026 write-up **carrying its own "Sponsored Post" label and affiliate links**, read at source, as the origin of the 1,500-nit, 30-degree and 58-gram figures. 4 Android Headlines, 15 October 2026, read at source, for the US$699 price, the 270 mAh cells, the three-hour translation figure and the four-microphone array; **the same piece calls the glasses camera-free, which INMO's own photography contradicts.** 5 Geeky Gadgets, 2 May 2026, a seven-day hands-on, read at source, for the five-hour figure, the 1,300 mAh case and the April price tiers; **the site discloses affiliate links and records no drawback.** 6 **A dedicated search of Lazada Singapore, Shopee Singapore and S$ listings returned no Singapore retailer, no distributor and no local price.** 7 A hi-fi and gear roundup of 16 October 2026, read at source, for all three prices and the Ray-Ban ship date; **the makers' own pages were not reached for these three, and the roundup gives no announcement dates. Hodinkee, Reddit, WatchUSeek, Variety and Forbes all refused this desk; one hands-on host returned an empty page and nothing is quoted from it.**

THE GOOD LIFE · H. MOSER & CIE.

H. Moser prices its Saquon Barkley tourbillon identically to the standard reference

Reference 3811-1205 lists at CHF 79,000 before Swiss VAT, in 97 pieces. So does the standard 3811-1200, on the maker's own site.

H. Moser & Cie. unveiled its first limited edition with an NFL player on **Monday 19 October**: the **Pioneer Cylindrical Tourbillon Skeleton Aventurine Saquon Barkley Edition**, reference **3811-1205**, in steel at **42.8mm**, limited to **97 pieces** for the running back's birth year.[1]

The number that makes it interesting is on Moser's own website. The Barkley edition lists at **CHF 79,000 excluding VAT**. The standard **3811-1200**, same case, same **HMC 811** calibre, same 74-hour reserve, lists at **CHF 79,000 excluding VAT**. The celebrity premium is zero francs; what you pay for is a domed aventurine subdial, a different lume colour and a rubber strap in place of alligator.[2]

The movement is the one Moser has sold since **2022**: **34 by 5.5mm**, **21,600 vibrations** an hour, **28 jewels**, **171 components**, a one-minute flying tourbillon at six and a cylindrical hairspring with two Breguet overcoils. The case runs **11.7mm**, or **15.3mm** over the domed crystal, to **120 metres**. The collaboration lives in the detailing, and it is quiet: **97 pieces for 1997**, and lume at the **2** and the **6** glowing a different colour — his jersey number. Barkley's own line beats the press release: **"It's super cool to be able to tell my kids and family that their father has a watch."**[13]

There is no Singapore price. Moser publishes none, its retailer page returns an error, and no coverage carries an S$ figure. The dollar price is itself contested: **US$99,600** in three outlets, **US$99,000** in two — one of which prints both, in its text and in its own spec table.[23]

CHF 0

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN THE BARKLEY EDITION'S LIST PRICE AND THE STANDARD REFERENCE'S, ON MOSER'S OWN SITE[2]

THE CHATTER · SEVENTY-TWO HOURS, ONE COMMENT

The honest state of the enthusiast conversation is that there isn't one. The only watch title with a comment thread open on the launch carried, three days in, **exactly one comment**: **"Go birds"**, posted at 23:30 on 19 October. The single named voice with a position is **Zach Blass**, and he takes it pre-emptively defensive — conceding **"some Philadelphia fans may have wanted more overt co-branding"** and arguing the restraint keeps the focus on Barkley's taste rather than on a gimmick. He discloses he is a Giants fan.[34]

THE SCEPTIC · A FOUR-YEAR-OLD WATCH WITH A NEW DIAL

The platform is the **2022** Pioneer Cylindrical Tourbillon Skeleton, and the launch coverage says so: same dimensions, same construction, same finishes. What has moved is the dollar. A hands-on of the debut reference in **May 2022** priced it at **US$86,900**; the 2026 edition is **US$99,600 — up 14.6 per cent** — for what Moser's own site says is the same Swiss-franc number. Then the geometry: **15.3mm** of thickness on a 42.8mm steel case, with a domed crystal over a domed stone dial.[35]

THREE THREADS THIS DESK STILL CANNOT CLOSE

No. 140 held the **Leica Q3 43 F1's** Singapore price, the **Technics** turntable's US price and wow-and-flutter figure, and whether the **Renaud Tixier** case is white or grey gold. **Four days of release roundups, read at source, resolved none of the three.** They stay open rather than be guessed.[6]

SOURCES 1 WWD, 19 October 2026, read at source via syndication, for the launch, the partnership's Met Gala origin and both quotations from Saquon Barkley and Edouard Meylan. 2 **H. Moser & Cie.'s own product pages for references 3811-1205 and 3811-1200, both read at source on 22 October 2026**, for the case, calibre, power reserve, limitation and the identical CHF 79,000 excluding-VAT list price on each. **Moser's news and retailer pages both return 404, so no Singapore authorised dealer could be confirmed, and no S$ price exists in any source.** 3 Monochrome Watches, c.19 October 2026, read at source, for the full movement specification, the dimensions, the CHF 85,400 VAT-inclusive and US$99,600 figures, the statement that the piece is based on the 2022 model, and the single reader comment quoted. 4 Time+Tide, 20 October 2026, read at source, for Zach Blass's assessment and disclosure; **its body text and its own spec table give different US prices, US$99,600 and US$99,000, and both are reported rather than reconciled.** 5 aBlogtoWatch, 12 May 2022, read at source, for the debut reference's US$86,900 price. 6 Four days of watch-release roundups for 19–22 October 2026, each read at source, which carry nothing on the three held items. **Hodinkee is blocked to this desk outright; WatchUSeek returns a payment wall and a bot challenge; WatchCrunch returns 403; Reddit refused for the ninth consecutive issue. Search snippets of forum criticism were found and are deliberately not quoted, because the threads could not be opened.**

SCREEN & SOUND · YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING

A24 expands its Elizabeth Holmes documentary to more than 2,500 screens

It opened on 855 screens and took $18,247 from each, against Street Fighter's $8,608 from 3,575. Its Rotten Tomatoes score has fallen from 100 to 97 as the sample tripled.

A24 announced this week that *You Can See Everything*, the **Nathan Fielder** and **Lance Oppenheim** documentary about **Elizabeth Holmes**, **"expands to 2500+ screens nationwide this weekend"** — an addition of more than **1,645** theatres to the 855 it opened on.[1]

The arithmetic behind the decision is on Box Office Mojo. In the weekend of **16–18 October** the film took **$15,601,418** from **855** screens — **$18,247** each — against *Street Fighter*'s **$30,775,377** from **3,575**, or **$8,608**. By Tuesday the **20th** the gap had widened: the documentary took **$3,073** a screen against the fighting film's **$801**, and finished the day only **$236,774** behind it on **2,720 fewer screens**.[2]

The critical number is moving the other way. Read at source on **22 October**, the Tomatometer stands at **97 per cent from 156 critic reviews**, with an audience score of **97**. Reporting in the days after release variously gave **100**, **99** and **98** — all true at the time, at a fraction of the sample. One figure in circulation is simply wrong, and this desk will not repeat it: the **A− CinemaScore** attributed to the film belongs to *Sense and Sensibility*.[3][4]

The premise explains the per-screen number better than the reviews do. A24's own synopsis: thirty-four days before she goes to prison, Holmes invites a sceptical crew to document her. It became a three-year project, runs **two hours and fifty-five minutes**, and sold out **more than 2,000 showings** on its opening weekend. *Street Fighter* still led the weekend at **$30.8m**, and the industry total ran to about **$101.6m**, up **45 per cent** year on year.[4][5]

3.8×

THE DOCUMENTARY'S PER-SCREEN TAKE AGAINST *STREET FIGHTER*'S ON TUESDAY 20 OCTOBER — $3,073 TO $801[2]

THE CHATTER · THE WHISTLEBLOWER WATCHED IT AND CATALOGUED THE PROPS

Tyler Shultz, who blew the whistle on Theranos, calls the film **"a piece of art with the intent of creating ambiguity"** that **"doesn't look far beyond the walls of the small condo"**. His objections are checkable, not aesthetic. The dismantled analyser Holmes lays on a kitchen table was a future version **"that was never completed and never used"**, not the Edison that actually ran: **"THAT IS NOT THE DEVICE."** The film shows a rented condo; during trial she lived on an estate listed at **$125 million**. And the figure the ambiguity rests on: Theranos told investors it made about **$108 million** in 2014 and recorded **little more than $100,000**.[6]

THE SCEPTIC · LOVED IT, AND SAYS DON'T WATCH IT

The sharpest line comes from someone who admires it. **Matthew Herper**, writing on **20 October**, argues that the film treats documented falsehoods as more debatable than they were, and that with a manipulator of this kind **"it's probably best to look away"**. His closing sentence is the whole review: **"I wish we could all just not look."** Against that sits the exhibition fact: A24 is about to put the film in **three times** as many rooms.[7]

SOURCES 1 ScreenRant, 21 October 2026, read at source, reporting A24's own post, for the 2,500-screen expansion and the 1,645-theatre calculation. **Single-sourced: Variety redirected to a payment wall and Forbes returned 403, so no second outlet could be read on the expansion.** ScreenRant's further claims — a reported ~$7m budget and a "second-best domestic debut for a non-concert documentary" ranking — name no data source and are not printed. 2 **Box Office Mojo's weekend-42 and 20 October daily charts, both read at source**, for every gross, theatre count and per-screen figure; **the per-screen comparisons are this desk's own arithmetic on those two tables. Its 21 October page returned "No data available", so no Wednesday figure is cited.** 3 **Rotten Tomatoes' own film page, read at source on 22 October 2026**, for 97 per cent from 156 critic reviews and the audience score. **The 98, 99 and 100 figures reported elsewhere were accurate at smaller review counts and are described as such rather than quoted as current.** 4 The Associated Press via NBC News, 18 October 2026, read at source, for the sellout count, the weekend industry total and **the A− CinemaScore, which belongs to *Sense and Sensibility*; no CinemaScore for this film was found in any source.** 5 **A24's own film page, read at source**, for the synopsis and the 2-hour-55-minute runtime; **Rotten Tomatoes gives 2h 54m, and the distributor's figure is preferred.** 6 Tyler Shultz, writing in STAT, 19 October 2026, read at source, for every quotation and for the SEC revenue figures, the estate valuation and the device description. 7 Matthew Herper, STAT, 20 October 2026, read at source.

THE FAMILY DESK · PHONES AFTER TEN

JAMA Pediatrics measures the ten o'clock line with sensors, not surveys

Each extra minute of phone use after 10pm cost 0.43 minutes of sleep across 7,591 nights. Singapore's MOE moved its locked bedtime to 10.30pm in January.

JAMA Pediatrics published a study on **Monday 19 October** that measured what teenagers actually do with their phones at night rather than asking them. **Yunyu Zhao, Lauren Hale** and **Dimitri Christakis** took **passively sensed** phone use and **Fitbit** sleep data from **425** adolescents inside the ABCD study — **7,591 person-nights**.[1]

The finding is a rate, and within the same teenager rather than between teenagers. Each extra minute of phone use after 10pm, measured against that child's own average, pushed sleep onset **0.87 minutes later** (95% CI 0.84–0.90) and shortened total sleep by **0.43 minutes** (CI −0.47 to −0.39), both at **P < .001**. In plain terms: an extra half-hour after ten pushes sleep about **26 minutes** later and costs about **13 minutes** of it. The estimates rose steadily at every later cutoff from 8pm to midnight.[1]

Two honest qualifications belong in the same breath. The raw night-level contrast — **20.05 minutes** less sleep, **64.73 minutes** later onset on heavy-use nights — carries standard deviations of **49.42** and **50.95**, larger than the means themselves. And the sample is **mean age 14.8**. **A twelve-year-old sits below the band this study actually measured**, which is the kind of thing a parent is rarely told.[1]

The policy number lines up almost exactly. From **January 2026** Singapore's **Ministry of Education** moved the nightly lock on government-issued Personal Learning Devices from **11pm to 10.30pm**, running to 6.30am, and barred secondary students from phones outside lesson time including recess. An MOE spokesperson said it **"can help students to manage device use before bedtime, and nudge them to sleep earlier"**. A survey published in **September 2025** found about a quarter of 13-to-17-year-olds on devices more than four hours a day on weekdays.[2]

26 min

LATER SLEEP ONSET FOR EVERY EXTRA HALF-HOUR OF POST-10PM PHONE USE, ON THE STUDY'S OWN WITHIN-PERSON RATE[1]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPOREAN PARENTS ON WHETHER A RULE CAN HOLD

Interviewed when the school rules were announced, parents were supportive and unconvinced in the same sentence. **Mr Aylwin Lam**, 48, prefers lockers to bags because students **"can find all sorts of ways to get around the rules"**. **Mr Kelvin Choo**, 60, asks **"who's going to be in charge to ensure that their phones are off or in the locker?"** **Ms Michelle Goh**: **"It will solve part of the problem, but not the whole problem."** A secondary teacher of ten years: **"Teachers can't be everywhere all at once."** The reported workaround is a dummy phone.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · IT MAY BE THE DISPLACEMENT, NOT THE SCREEN

Dr Daniel Bigman, not an author, offers the deflationary reading in one line: **"For one, any kind of activity before sleep time will displace your sleep."** The authors themselves say the associations are not causal. And the proximal effect is small and short-lived: phone use in the **final five minutes** before sleep added **0.74 minutes** of wakefulness (CI 0.50–0.98), and became negligible once the window widened to twenty. The paper measures a displacement of time more cleanly than it measures a harm. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[14]

SOURCES 1 **Zhao Y, Hale L, Christakis DA, "Evening Phone Use and Sleep Outcomes Among Youth",** ***JAMA Pediatrics*****, published online 19 October 2026, DOI 10.1001/jamapediatrics.2026.4902 — read at source**, for the design, the sample of 425 adolescents and 7,591 person-nights, the mean age and sex split, every coefficient and confidence interval, the dose gradient from 8pm to midnight, the raw night-level contrasts with their standard deviations, the proximal five-minute result and the authors' own statement that the associations are not causal. **The practical translations (26 minutes, 13 minutes) are this desk's arithmetic on the published within-person rates.** 2 The Straits Times via AsiaOne, 30 November 2025, read at source, for the January 2026 school rules, the move of the Personal Learning Device lock from 11pm to 10.30pm, the MOE spokesperson's quoted words, the September 2025 survey figures and the MOH screen-time bands.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE FIRST PHONE

A Philadelphia study finds the account, not the phone, carries the effect

Of 3,486 twelve-year-olds without a phone, 1,546 had one by thirteen. Owning one tripled the odds of a social-media account, and three mediators explain 80 per cent of the association.

A team at the **Children's Hospital of Philadelphia** and the **University of Pennsylvania** — **Ziv Bren**, **Ran Barzilay** and colleagues — published a study in **Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry** on **30 September 2026**, picked up by the press on 17 October, that follows exactly this reader's child. They took **3,486** children with no smartphone at a mean age of **11.82** and followed them to the age-13 assessment. **1,546 acquired a phone; 1,940 did not.**[1]

The headline effects are real and small. Adjusting for baseline scores, demographics, puberty, parental monitoring and other devices, acquisition was associated with standardised increases of **0.11** on internalizing symptoms (CI 0.05–0.18), **0.09** on attention (0.03–0.16) and **0.10** on total symptoms (0.04–0.17). A tenth of a standard deviation is not a crisis, and the authors do not call it one.[1]

The mechanism is the finding worth acting on. Three mediators account for about **80 per cent** of the association: **social-media account ownership at 35.5 per cent**, **total screen time at 27.9** and **bedtime media use at 16.9**, all at $p \leq 0.002$. And the single largest number in the paper is the gateway itself: acquiring a phone carried an odds ratio of **3.22** (CI 2.66–3.91) for owning a social-media account.[1]

Read together with p12, that reframes the decision a parent actually faces. It is not phone or no phone. It is account or no account, and where the device sleeps — two of the three mediators, and the two a household can set without negotiating with a school.[1]

3.22

ODDS RATIO FOR OWNING A SOCIAL-MEDIA ACCOUNT AFTER ACQUIRING A FIRST PHONE, IN 3,486 TWELVE-YEAR-OLDS[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE AUTHORS SAY AGAINST THEMSELVES

The limitations section is unusually frank, and it is the reason to trust the rest. There is **no propensity matching**: the families who bought a phone may differ from those who did not in ways no covariate caught. The digital measures are self- and caregiver-reported. Follow-up is **one year only**. Nothing captures *how* the devices were used. And mediators and outcomes were measured at the same time, so **the temporal order is unconfirmed** — the account may follow the symptoms as easily as precede them.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · EIGHTY THOUSAND ADULTS SAY THE AGE DOES NOT PREDICT MUCH

Christopher J. Ferguson of **Stetson University** ran the question backwards in *Clinical Neuropsychiatry* in **June 2026**, on **80,878** young adults. In his model **adverse childhood experiences** dominated at **β = −0.246**, while **age of smartphone ownership** came in at **−0.049** and age of tablet ownership at **+0.060** — both below his pre-declared smallest effect size of interest. His conclusion is the line to keep: advice to parents to avoid earlier access **"appears to be unwarranted"**. The model explains **8.1 per cent** of variance, and **he reports no confidence intervals. General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

SOURCES 1 **Bren Z, Tran KT, Clinton R, Visoki E, Tran LA, Michel N, Moore TM, Pimentel SD, Barzilay R, "Smartphone acquisition as an inflection point in early adolescence digital exposome: relevance to mental health",** ***Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry*** **5:1940646, published 30 September 2026, DOI 10.3389/frcha.2026.1940646 — read at source**, for the sample, the baseline mean age, the acquisition split, every standardised coefficient and confidence interval, all three mediation shares and their p-values, the 3.22 odds ratio, and every limitation listed in the Chatter box, which is drawn from the paper's own limitations section. **The paper is dated outside this issue's news window; its press cycle fell on 17 October and it is run here as the companion to the in-window JAMA Pediatrics study on p12.**
2 **Ferguson CJ, "Adverse Childhood Events, Not Age of Acquiring Smartphones or Tablets, Predict Mental Health in Young Adults",** ***Clinical Neuropsychiatry*** **23(3):243–247, June 2026 — read at source**, for the sample of 80,878, the Mental Health Quotient outcome, all three beta coefficients, the pre-declared smallest effect size of interest, the model R-squared and the quoted conclusion.

THE MACRO DESK · THURSDAY'S REPRICING

Meta's cash outflow knocked 17 basis points off the US ten-year on Thursday

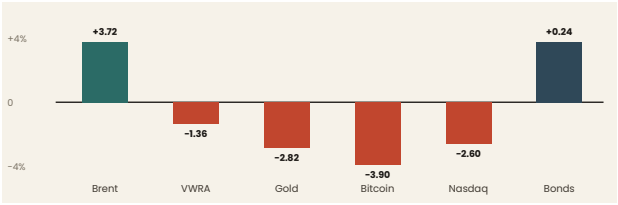
The 10-year fell to 4.96 per cent, its sharpest one-day drop since March 2023, while Brent rose 3.72 per cent to $112.87 and gold fell 2.82 per cent.

The **US ten-year Treasury** yield fell **17 basis points** to **4.96 per cent** on **Thursday 22 October** in New York, its steepest single-day drop since **March 2023**, after **Meta** disclosed its first cash outflow in more than a decade and the **Nasdaq Composite** fell **2.60 per cent**.[1][2]

The session ran in two halves that pointed opposite ways. In the morning it was an oil shock: Houthi strikes on Saudi targets took **Brent** up **3.72 per cent** to **$112.87** and **WTI** to **$99.05**, a five-month high, and the read was a Federal Reserve pushed toward further increases. By the afternoon it was a growth scare: Meta fell **7.0 per cent** despite beating, **Tesla 3.1** after cutting 2026 capital spending to about **$20bn**, and **Intel, AMD, SanDisk and Marvell** each more than **8**. The **Philadelphia Semiconductor Index** fell **6.7 per cent**.[2]

The curve says which half won. Two-year and ten-year fell almost together — **16** and **17 basis points** — leaving **2s10s** at **+31**, one basis point flatter than No. 140. A near-parallel shift is the signature of a flight to quality, not of a repriced Fed path. The data that day was hawkish and ignored: **initial jobless claims fell 6,000 to 194,000**.[1][2]

Gold did the un-gold thing, and that is the week's most instructive print. On a day of Middle East strikes and an equity rout it fell **2.82 per cent** to **$4,024.21**. The mechanism is opportunity cost, not fear: an oil-driven reflation impulse lifts the expected policy path, and bullion pays no coupon. Bitcoin behaved as high-beta Nasdaq rather than as anything else, down **3.90 per cent** to **$81,338**. One timing note: **VWRA** and the **Straits Times Index** both closed *before* New York's afternoon, so their falls are Wednesday's America, not Thursday's.[3][4]



One session, six instruments: percentage change on Thursday 22 October 2026. Bonds = AGGU, single-sourced. VWRA and the bond proxy closed in London before the New York afternoon. A *Meridian* original, from the levels in the strip on p2.

THE CHATTER · TWO STRATEGISTS ON WHAT ACTUALLY BROKE

Paul Nolte, senior wealth adviser at **Murphy & Sylvest**: **"Investors are starting to realize that there are some holes in the AI story"** — and the mechanism he names is index weight, which is how one company's capital-spending confession becomes everybody's afternoon. **Thomas Urano** of **Sage Advisory**, on the other side of the trade: **"The flight-to-quality trade is winning in the Treasury space."** Of **111** S&P 500 companies reported by Thursday, **83 per cent** had beaten.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · A CORRECTION IS NOT A BURSTING

Rick Newman, writing on **17 October**, says he has **"a different interpretation"** from the outlets reaching for "rout": a fast correction, with a far better picture for anyone holding a long horizon. His figures — the record high on **6 October**, technology then down nearly **8 per cent** — are five days stale and predate Thursday's session, which cuts both ways. **This desk could not find a strategist calling Thursday's move overdone after Thursday.** FLIGHT TO QUALITY OIL-BID HIKING FED **Explanation, not advice.**[5]

SOURCES 1 **The US Treasury's own Daily Treasury Par Yield Curve file for October 2026, read at source on home.treasury.gov**, for the 2-year at 4.65 per cent, the 10-year at 4.96 and the 30-year at 5.29 on 22 October, and for the previous day's levels from which every change above is computed; the 2s10s spread is this desk's arithmetic on those two series. Corroborated independently at a second quote source. 2 Reuters market wrap of 22 October 2026, read through a licensed syndication because **reuters.com itself refused this desk**, for the Nasdaq, S&P and Dow closes, the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index fall, the single-stock moves, Meta's cash outflow and Tesla's capital-spending cut, the jobless-claims print, the earnings-beat count and both strategist quotations; the sharpest-drop-since-March-2023 characterisation from the same reporting. 3 Trading Economics and, independently, Kitco for gold at $4,024.21; Trading Economics and Oilprice.com for Brent at $112.87; CoinGecko and Coinbase for bitcoin at $81,338 — **each instrument read at two separate sources. No official LBMA fix was available; the gold figure is OTC spot from two vendors.** 4 Yahoo's chart API and justETF for VWRA at $189.66; Trading Economics and Yahoo for the Straits Times Index at 5,415.14.

THE RABBIT HOLE · ULTRALIGHT BACKPACKING

Ultralight backpacking judges a kit list on Lighterpack, to the gram

A base weight under ten pounds is the entry ticket, and the initiation is publishing your gear list to the gram for a million strangers to pick apart.

Everything you carry outdoors for a week — shelter, bed, kitchen, clothes, electronics — weighed in grams, minus the food, water and fuel you will consume. That figure is your **base weight**, and the hobby is organised entirely around it. Under **10 pounds**, about 4.5 kilograms, is **ultralight**. Ten to twenty is lightweight. Over twenty is what the rest of the world calls backpacking.[1]

The appeal is in a sentence from **Rafael 'Horsecake' Mujica**, a former moderator of the largest ultralight forum on the internet, describing his first carry after a Marine Corps career spent under a hundred pounds: **"walking around snow-capped mountains at 12,000 ft with a pack the size of a chihuahua felt like I had helium balloons strapped to my back. I never looked back."**[1]

The initiation is a ritual called the **shakedown**. You publish a complete inventory of your kit, itemised to the gram, on a free web tool called **Lighterpack**, and the community takes it apart line by line. Mujica's description is the honest one: **"This is where you bear your soul... I mean, gear closet for the entire r/Ultralight community to peer at and critically analyze, down to the gram."** The first purchase is not a tent. It is a kitchen scale.[1]

The scale of it is real but not what the marketing suggests. **r/Ultralight** runs to roughly **999,000** members on a third-party tracker, up **128,000** in a year; it had just over **64,000** in early 2018. The **Pacific Crest Trail** permit is capped at **50 starts a day**, and only **49.6 per cent** of last year's class got the date they asked for. Of the **790** hikers surveyed, **24.1 per cent** were forty or over; **45 per cent** held a bachelor's degree and **25.1** a master's. They spent an average of **$10,339** on the hike and **$1,701** of it on gear.[2][3]

10 lb

THE BASE-WEIGHT LINE THAT SEPARATES ULTRALIGHT FROM LIGHTWEIGHT — EVERYTHING BUT FOOD, WATER AND FUEL[1]

THE CHATTER · THE NUMBERS THAT EMBARRASS THE HOBBY

Kelly Floro of *The Trek*, writing on **23 September**, put the two long-trail surveys side by side. Average PCT starting base weight: **19.6 lb in 2016, 17.8 lb in 2025**. On the Appalachian Trail: **19 lb in 2016, 20 lb in 2025**. Nine years of new fabrics, new shelters and new everything, and the pack on the average back is within a pound of where it was. Her own explanation is that the perception of an ultralight takeover is driven **"partly by marketing and social media"**.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THERE IS A RUNG BELOW ULTRALIGHT WITH A WARNING ON IT

The community's own ladder runs novice, lightweight, ultralight, **SUL** under five pounds, **XUL** under three — and then **stupid light**, which Backpacking Light's long-running thread of that name describes as a step that can be fatal. The items people say they regret cutting are specific and repeat: bear canisters, rain gear, insulation. One poster recounts near-hypothermia after moving to a lighter quilt, and switching to synthetic insulation afterwards. The term is not a joke the hobby tells about itself; it is a category of accident.[6]

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The Big Three — pack, shelter and sleep system, priced at the makers' own stores this week (p16) — and **the cottage tier**, where you do not buy so much as commission: a monthly lottery, a six-month queue, and a workshop on a farm outside Keswick (p17).[4]

SOURCES 1 Rafael 'Horsecake' Mujica, former r/Ultralight moderator, writing for Garage Grown Gear, 19 July 2022, read at source, for the base-weight tiers and their definitions, the shakedown ritual and both quotations. 2 Halfway Anywhere's PCT Hiker Survey for the 2025 class, read at source: 790 respondents, the permit and start-date figures, the full demographic breakdown, the $10,339 and $1,701 spend figures and the base-weight series. 3 **The US Forest Service's own Pacific Crest Trail page, read at source**, for the 50-starts-a-day cap; **pcta.org returned 403 on every path, so no PCTA page was read.** 4 The Appalachian Trail Conservancy's own thru-hiking page for the one-in-three completion rate and the trail length; **the US Bureau of Economic Analysis's own outdoor-recreation release, data year 2024, published 5 March 2026**, for $696.7bn and 2.4 per cent of GDP. 5 Kelly Floro, *The Trek*, 23 September 2026, read at source, for both survey series and the quoted explanation. 6 The *Examples of "Stupid Light"* thread on Backpacking Light, read at source, for the ladder, the regretted items and the hypothermia account. 7 The Big Three prices and weights are sourced in full on p16. 8 The cottage makers' order systems are sourced in full on p17. 9 The fabric and shelter releases are sourced in full on p17. **Reddit refused this desk on every route for the ninth consecutive issue — the API, the old interface and eleven mirrors — so not one live r/Ultralight thread was read. The subscriber figure is a third-party tracker and is labelled as such, and the description of the sub's culture comes from a signed article by a former moderator, not from the sub.**

THE DEEP END · THE BIG THREE

Durston holds four of the seven most-carried shelters on the Pacific Crest Trail

A one-man design operation that did not exist a decade ago sells a 745-gram tent for US$269. The Dyneema version of the same idea costs US$679.

Almost all the weight and almost all the money sit in three objects: pack, shelter, sleep system. The entry point of real quality is neither cheap nor exotic. A **Six Moon Designs Lunar Solo** is **US$260** at **740 grams**, plus **$35** if you want the maker to seam-seal it. A **Durston X-Mid 1** is **$269** at **745 grams**. A **ULA CDT** in the new UltraGrid fabric is **$199.99**.[1]

The sweet spot is a four-item bill you can total today. **Durston Kakwa 55** pack at **$279** and about **870 grams**, rated to a **20-kilogram** load; **X-Mid 1** at **$269**; **Katabatic Palisade 30°F** quilt from **$379**; **Therm-a-Rest NeoAir XLite NXT** pad at **$199.95**, **370 grams**. That is **$1,126.95** and roughly **2,865 grams** — 6.3 pounds — leaving about 3.7 pounds for clothing, cooking, water, electronics and first aid inside a sub-ten-pound base weight.[1][2]

Above that the curve steepens, and you should know by how much. The high-end equivalent — **Zpacks Arc Pro 60L** at **$449** and **628 grams**, **Plex Solo Pro** at **$649** and **373**, **Katabatic Flex 22°F** at **$409**, the same pad — comes to **$1,706.95** and about **2,031 grams**. That is **$580 to save 834 grams**: **$19.75 an ounce**. What the money buys is laminate rather than woven fabric — no water absorption, no sag, a taut pitch in the morning — and a shorter service life with a care regime attached.[1]

> ***"Unfortunately Zpacks has never bothered to fix this, so lots of people have shelters dying early — but the problem is with the design, not the material."***

Four of the seven most-carried shelters on the Pacific Crest Trail last year were Durstons, and the top two were his. He is one designer with a website, out-selling the brands with retail distribution.[2]

$19.75

PER OUNCE SAVED, MOVING FROM THE SWEET-SPOT BIG FOUR TO THE HIGH-END BIG FOUR — $580 FOR 1.8 POUNDS[1]

THE CHATTER · A MAKER NAMING A RIVAL'S DEFECT IN PUBLIC

The best-attributed exchange in this hobby is a 2021 Backpacking Light thread on how Dyneema shelters die. **Arthur** posted corner-failure photographs from a **Zpacks Duplex after about 50 nights**: **"Same on all 4 corners. Never in high winds... Zpacks said it was 'normal' wear and tear." Steve Cockburn** lost two Zpacks tarps at three and four years and concluded they were **"not worth the investment"**. Then **Dan Durston**, posting under his own company's name, diagnosed a competitor on the record: the corners **"are pulling on the DCF on the bias (diagonal) which causes the material to pull apart"**. **Murali C** framed the puzzle: **"Bad batch of DCF or user error?"**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT A $749 TENT STILL NEEDS

Tarptent's own product page concedes that Dyneema floors are **"more prone to both punctures and abrasion than nylon"** and that a groundsheet **"can greatly extend the lifespan"** — a seven-hundred-dollar shelter asking for a fifty-dollar accessory to survive. Quilt ratings are worse: there is **no standardised test** behind them. And the resale number is the one to sit with. Zpacks runs its own used channel: a lightly used **Duplex Pro at $699** against $849 new, a **Plex Solo Pro at $549** against $649. Liquid, which is the good news. An asset, which it is not.[4][5]

SOURCES 1 **Every price and weight on this page was read at the maker's own store page on 22 October 2026** — Durston Gear, Zpacks, Hyperlite Mountain Gear, Six Moon Designs, ULA Equipment, Katabatic Gear, Gossamer Gear, Tarptent, Feathered Friends and Cascade Designs. Several makers display a "sale price" label with no compare-at figure, which is noted where it occurs; the four-item totals and the cost-per-ounce figures are this desk's arithmetic on those prices and weights. **The Therm-a-Rest NeoAir XLite NXT was out of stock in every size with a waitlist open when its price was read.** 2 Halfway Anywhere's 2025 PCT survey, read at source, for the most-carried packs, shelters, quilts and pads in rank order, from which the Durston count is taken. 3 The Backpacking Light thread *How did your DCF shelter age and expire?*, November–December 2021, read at source, for all four quotations, with usernames as posted; Dan Durston posts there under his own company's name. 4 Tarptent's own Notch Li product page, read at source, for the Dyneema floor caveat; SectionHiker and Garage Grown Gear for the absence of a standardised quilt-rating test. 5 Zpacks's own bargain and lightly-used listings, read at source on 21 October 2026.

THE DEEP END · COMMISSIONS AND FABRICS

Timmermade allocates order slots by lottery; Superior Wilderness Designs quotes six months

Superior Wilderness Designs quotes October orders for April. Mountain Laurel Designs closed its store entirely and reopens on 31 October.

Past a certain point you stop buying and start commissioning, and the makers have invented four ways to ration themselves. **Mountain Laurel Designs** simply shuts: its homepage reads **"STORE STATUS: CLOSED – REOPENS ON OCTOBER 31"**, and **Ron Bell** explains that **"Interest in super ultralight gear has grown far beyond our production capacity"**, so 2026 runs on monthly order windows.[1]

Superior Wilderness Designs in Michigan publishes a queue instead: **"The estimated ship date for orders placed in October is April"**, because **"our current production is only about 15-20 backpacks per week"**. **Timmermade** refuses a waitlist altogether and runs a **monthly lottery** in which entrants must answer a gear-knowledge question correctly. And **Atom Packs**, on a farm outside Keswick, builds to your measurements from **$215** for a 450-gram frameless pack, with a policy stated flatly: **"All completed custom orders are final."**[1][2]

The year's real news is a fabric, and it exists because the last one failed. First-generation **Challenge Ultra** delaminated under diagonal shear. In **September 2026** the fabric counter listed **Ultra TenX** at **$28 a half-yard**, built with **"three-directional UHMWPE cross-ply reinforcement for tear resistance and dimensional stability"** over **"a 0.75 mil PET film backing"** — precisely the two things the delamination was blamed on. Weeks later **Zpacks** shipped the **Arc Pro**, **$449** and **628 grams**, with TenX on the wear face.[3]

$60

PER OUNCE SAVED BY THE DYNEEMA X-DOME OVER ITS SILPOLY TWIN — ABOUT $430 FOR 7.2 OUNCES[4]

SINGAPORE — THE HONEST VERSION

There is no local community. A dedicated search found **no Singapore ultralight group, forum or club**, and **no Singapore retailer stocks Hyperlite, Zpacks, Durston, Katabatic or Atom Packs** — you import or you do not own it. Outdoor equipment is **non-dutiable**, and **9 per cent GST** applies once landed value passes **S$400**, which an $849 shelter comfortably does; **Durston's own shipping page** collects taxes at checkout for the US, Canada, Japan and Europe and explicitly **not** for **"Asia (except Japan)"**. The real cost here is the airfare and the leave.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE TEACHERS ARE NOW RETRACTING

Three of the hobby's biggest educators spent this autumn walking things back. **Darwin onthetrail**, 358,000 subscribers, published **"Bad Backpacking Advice I've Given Over the Years"** on **11 October**; **Dan Becker**, 520,000, ran **"The Backpacking Mistakes Nobody Talks About"**. And Halfway Anywhere, the most data-literate outfit in the hobby, appends a buyer warning beside the two most-carried quilts on the Pacific Crest Trail. **This desk could not read what that warning alleges, because the thread it links to is on Reddit.**[6]

NEXT DESCENTS

Violin making (lutherie) — a wood-hoarding culture, a three-hundred-year varnish argument and a blind test nobody likes.

Archery (recurve, compound & traditional) — a millimetre sport with named bowyers and a real Singapore range.

Home machining (the lathe and the mill) — tenths of a thousandth in a garage, and a second-hand market that never depreciates.

SOURCES 1 **Mountain Laurel Designs' own homepage and Superior Wilderness Designs' own lead-time page, both read at source 22 October 2026**, for the closure notice, Ron Bell's statement, the April ship date and the 15–20-packs-a-week production figure, each quoted verbatim. 2 **Timmermade's own site** for the monthly lottery, the gear-knowledge question and the non-transferable codes; **Atom Packs's own site** for the custom range, its prices and weights and the returns policy as quoted. 3 **Ripstop by the Roll's own Challenge Ultra TenX listing, dated 24 September 2026 and read at source**, for the price, the areal weight and the construction description quoted; **Zpacks's own Arc Pro listing** for the price, weight and fabric layout. The account of first-generation Ultra delamination comes from Backpacking Light threads on the subject, read at source. 4 Katie Jackson, *The Trek*, 19 October 2026, read at source, for the Dyneema premium and her refusal to recommend it. 5 **Singapore Customs and IRAS, read at source**, for the non-dutiable classification and the S$400 low-value-goods threshold; **Durston Gear's own shipping page** for the quoted tax-collection exclusion covering Asia. **The finding that no Singapore ultralight community or stockist exists is a negative result from a dedicated search, not an absence of effort; the one local shop list found is dated 2021 and its addresses are not printed.** 6 The named creators' own published video titles and dates, read from their channel feeds on 22 October 2026, and Katie Jackson, *The Trek*, 22 September 2026.

FITNESS · FOUR MINUTES A DAY

Penn State trial puts four minutes a day against a waitlist control

Ninety-seven adults averaging 74 years old gained 4.22 chair stands in twelve weeks. The control group lost 28 per cent of its participants; the intervention group lost 11.

A **Penn State** release on **Tuesday 20 October** put a twelve-week randomised trial back in front of the public, and the trial is more interesting than the headline. **Smita Dandekar, Christopher Sciamanna** and colleagues randomised **97** inactive adults over 65 with difficulty walking — mean age **74**, baseline activity about **18 minutes a week** — to **four minutes a day** of functional strength work or to a delayed-treatment control.[1][2]

The protocol is almost comically small: push-ups, chair stands, two-arm rows and stair stepping, **thirty seconds on, thirty seconds off**, with bands, a stepper and a daily email. Participants did it on about **81 per cent** of days — roughly **22 minutes a week**. At twelve weeks the between-group differences were **2.28 seconds** faster on five-times sit-to-stand (95% CI 0.47–4.09), **3.57 seconds** longer on one-legged stance (0.61–6.53) and **4.22 more repetitions** in a thirty-second chair stand (2.78–5.66). Sciamanna's framing is worth keeping: **"The human body is designed to improve very quickly."**[1][2]

On the question this reader actually asks — does lifting help you sleep — a second paper landed on **20 October** and should be treated as a hint, not a finding. In **25** adults with moderate-to-severe sleep apnoea, eight weeks of resistance training moved the Pittsburgh index by **−3.2** against **+0.2** in controls (p = 0.004). But the control group still trained twice a week, the instruments are all subjective, and the one objective sleepiness measure showed nothing at all.[3]

4.22

EXTRA REPETITIONS IN A THIRTY-SECOND CHAIR STAND AT TWELVE WEEKS, ON FOUR MINUTES A DAY (95% CI 2.78–5.66)[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE MINIMUM-DOSE LITERATURE ALREADY SAID

Peter Attia's team worked the same question in May from a Bayesian network meta-analysis of **192 studies**: twice a week at low load with multiple sets returns a strength effect of **1.23** against **1.60** for the best protocol — about **77 per cent** of the maximum. But the check on "four minutes" sits in the same analysis: **every multi-set protocol improved mobility; single-set protocols were no different from control.** Their stated minimum is two sessions a week, **three to four sets**, short of failure. **Dr Pak Androulakis-Korakakis** reached a similar floor in 2024, and added that minimum dose is for when time is limited, not a default.[4][5]

THE SCEPTIC · A WAITLIST CONTROL, AND A HEAD START

Four problems, all visible in the paper. **The control is a waitlist**, and across **333 trials** in a 2024 methods review waitlist designs returned effect sizes of **0.95** against **0.63** for care-as-usual, with the authors recommending against them. **Attrition was differential**: **5 of 44** lost from the intervention arm against **15 of 53** from the control, p = 0.04. **The groups did not start level**: the trial's own figure shows the intervention arm beginning around **12.2 seconds** on sit-to-stand against the control's **14.5** — a 2.3-second head start on a 2.28-second effect. And the abstract reports no significant adverse events while the results section reports **seven, in six participants**. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[2][6]

SOURCES 1 Penn State's release, carried on ScienceDaily, 21 October 2026, read at source, for both quotations. 2 **Dandekar S, Kurth J, Shang Y et al., "Brief daily functional strength training to improve functional performance in older adults with mobility disability: A randomized trial", *PLOS ONE* 2026;21(3):e0336748, registered NCT05697497 — read at source**, for the design, the sample of 97, the population characteristics, the protocol, the 81 per cent adherence, all three between-group results with their confidence intervals, the differential attrition and its p-value, the baseline figures in figure 2, and the discrepancy between the abstract's adverse-event statement and the results section's seven events in six participants. **The paper was published in March 2026; the in-window peg is the Penn State release of 20–21 October.** 3 de Almeida JRV et al., *Sleep and Breathing*, 20 October 2026, 30(6):296, read at source via the NCBI E-utilities endpoint because **PubMed itself returned 429**, for the sample of 25, the index changes and their p-values, the control group's own training schedule and the null result on the Epworth scale. 4 Peter Attia with Nicholas Nelson and Michael Rae, peterattiamd.com, 30 May 2026, read at source, discussing Currier et al. (2023) in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, for the 192-study meta-analysis, the standardised mean differences quoted, the single-set mobility finding and their stated minimum protocol. 5 Dr Pak Androulakis-Korakakis, Stronger By Science, 13 March 2024, read at source — **dated here because it is not new.** 6 Cuijpers P, Miguel C, Harrer M et al., *Epidemiology and Psychiatric Sciences*, 6 November 2024, read at source, for the 333-trial comparison of waitlist against care-as-usual controls and the authors' recommendation. **Nothing is attributed to any longevity commentator this desk could not read at source.**

THE DIARY · FOUR DEADLINES

Gardens by the Bay takes the world premiere of The Story of Studio Ghibli

Tickets run S$39 for a Singapore-resident adult, S$29 for a child, from 18 December to 4 July. ART SG's early-bird two-for-$40 closes on 24 November.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

18 Dec–4 Jul ★ **The Story of Studio Ghibli — world premiere**
WEST LAWN, GARDENS BY THE BAY · **RESIDENT ADULT S$39, CHILD S$29 · NO ON-SALE DATE PUBLISHED**

21–24 Jan ★ **ART SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · **EARLY BIRD TWO ADULTS S$40 UNTIL 24 NOV**, THEN S$80 · **16 AND UNDER FREE**

13–22 Nov **Singapore Writers Festival 2026**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE · **FESTIVAL PASS S$30, YOUTH S$15**, 100+ PROGRAMMES

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th edition**
ESPLANADE · 40 EVENTS, SEVERAL FREE · FROM **S$29**

4–6 Dec **Singapore Comic Con 2026**
MARINA BAY SANDS · **TWO-DAY S$68, ONE-DAY S$38 · FREE ONLY UNDER 8**

9–13 Dec **The Nutcracker · Singapore Ballet**
ESPLANADE THEATRE · **S$110 / 95 / 75 / 55** · DISTINCT FROM NOVEMBER'S TOURING PRODUCTION

29–30 Jan **Kenshi Yonezu · GHOST world tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · **DATE CONFIRMED AT THE PROMOTER; PRICES UNVERIFIED**

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

to 13 Dec ★ **Renaissance Masterpieces from the Louvre**
NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · **FINAL-WEEK TIMED TICKETS OPEN NOON, SAT 31 OCT · 15 AND UNDER NEED NO TIMED TICKET**

31 Oct–28 Mar ★ **Mariko Mori · All That Shines**
MORI ART MUSEUM · **ADVANCE DISCOUNT CLOSES FRI 30 OCT**; WEEKDAY ¥2,800, ONLINE ¥2,600

28 Oct–8 Feb **Shojo Manga Infinity · Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato**
NATIONAL ART CENTER · **ADVANCE ¥2,000 CLOSES 27 OCT**, THEN ¥2,200 · 15 AND UNDER FREE

10 Nov 2PM ★ **Ghibli Park · January passes released**
JAPAN TIME · PREMIUM **¥7,300 ADULT, ¥3,650 CHILD · LAWSON TICKET OR KLOOK ONLY**

5 Dec ★ **Hatsu Basho · advance sales open**
TOKYO, TOURNAMENT 10–24 JAN · **NOVEMBER'S KYUSHU BASHO IS SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS**

13 Nov–11 Jan **Magical Winter · Warner Bros. Studio Tour Tokyo**
NERIMA · ADULT **¥6,300–7,300**, JUNIOR 12–17 **¥5,200–6,000**

11–31 Jan **Australian Open 2027**
MELBOURNE PARK · DATES CONFIRMED · **PRICE BANDS STILL UNVERIFIED**, THE TICKETER REFUSED AGAIN

PLANNING NOTES · AND WHAT THIS DESK DROPPED

Four deadlines fall before the next fortnight is out, and three of them are Tokyo prices that expire while you are still in Singapore: **Shojo Manga Infinity's advance closes 27 October**, **Mariko Mori's online discount on 30 October**, and the **Louvre show's final-week timed tickets open at noon on 31 October** — nothing else admits you after 6 December, and the door sells none of it. Then **ART SG's two-for-$40 on 24 November**, **Ghibli Park's January release at 2pm on 10 November** and **sumo on 5 December**. **For a twelve-year-old the free list is long:** under-16s at ART SG, 15-and-under at both National Art Center shows — and at the Louvre they need no timed ticket at all — junior high and under at Mori. The trap is Comic Con, where free entry stops at eight. **Dropped for want of a bookable primary source:** a stadium-scale December concert carried only by resale sites; the Singapore marathon, whose own site still serves 2025; the Sapporo Snow Festival, same problem; Christmas Wonderland, which has published no 2026 dates; and the 2027 Formula 1, whose own ticket page is still selling a sold-out 2026. **Still barred:** Post Malone, and the Dee Dee Bridgewater duo of 29 October, cancelled.[1][2][3]

SOURCES 1 **Every Singapore row was confirmed at a primary source — the venue's, organiser's or promoter's own page, each read at source on 22 October 2026**: Gardens by the Bay and the exhibition's own site for the Ghibli premiere, its dates, hours and both price tiers; artsg.com for the fair dates and the full early-bird table; the Singapore Writers Festival, Esplanade, Singapore Ballet, the Affordable Art Fair and Singapore Comic Con for their own dates and prices. **The Affordable Art Fair publishes no ticket price on its own site and none is invented. ART SG's ticket page carries 2026 day-labels and an impossible Saturday opening hour, evidently typographical; its own fair page gives 22–24 January 2027 cleanly, and the Saturday hours are not printed. Kenshi Yonezu's date and venue are confirmed at the promoter; Ticketmaster Singapore returned 403 and a block response, so no price is given.** 2 **Every Japanese row was confirmed at the museum's, park's or association's own English page, read at source**: the National Art Center for both its exhibitions, including the noon 31 October on-sale, the 6 December expiry and the under-15 exemption; the Mori Art Museum for its dates, prices and the 30 October advance deadline; Warner Bros. Studio Tour Tokyo for all three age bands; Ghibli Park for the 10 November release and the full price table; the Japan Sumo Association and its official agent for the Kyushu sell-out and the 5 December Hatsu Basho on-sale.

THE TABLE · FOUR SINGAPORE OPENINGS

A Tokyo fried-sando chain brings 34 varieties to ION Orchard next month

Age.3 has sold more than a million fried sandos worldwide and queues ran to two hours in Ginza. Creamier's Base Gelato opens three days a week and sells six things.

The biggest arrival is not open yet, and the honest thing to say is that nobody in Singapore has eaten it. **Age.3** takes **#B4-64/65 at ION Orchard** in **mid-November** — no date announced, no hours, no local prices. The format is specific: coarse-crumbed Japanese milk bread, baked daily, dried, deep-fried until crisp, then split and filled to order. The bread is the fried element, which is what separates it from a katsu sando. It grew out of a fruit-sandwich shop in **Kama City, Fukuoka**, opened in **Ginza in December 2023**, and has since reached Shanghai, Sydney, Manila and Bangkok on more than **a million** sandos. There are **34 varieties**.[1]

Base Gelato, at **198 Joo Chiat Road**, is the opposite proposition and the only one here with a review. It is **Creamier**'s hole-in-the-wall, open **Friday to Sunday, noon to 7pm**, takeaway only, six items at nett prices: **Joo Chiat Heritage S$10** — coconut gelato, smoked gula melaka and an ondeh ondeh dango skewer — **Kaya Butter Toast S$9**, **Matchagato S$12** and a Valrhona Black Forest at S$12.[2]

O/Sio opens at **38 Tanjong Pagar Road** on **Wednesday 4 November**, the first overseas outpost of a Tokyo room run by **Shusaku Toba** — Italian food, charcoal-grilled meat and natural wine, with mains from **S$18.80**. No reservation system has been announced and the group's own site does not yet mention Singapore. And **Hama-Sushi**, the Zensho-owned conveyor giant whose plates start at **¥110** in Japan, is slated for **Pasir Ris Mall** in November — with, in its own coverage's words, no official opening date.[3][4]

3 of 4

OF THIS WEEK'S OPENINGS CANNOT BE JUDGED: TWO ARE NOT OPEN, AND ONE HAS A SINGLE REVIEW[1][2][3]

THE BUZZ · UNANIMOUS ON THE QUEUE, SILENT ON THE TASTE

Every Singapore write-up of Age.3 is anticipation, and all of it is about logistics. The Honeycombers' **Amelia Ang** queued an hour in Ginza and warns: **"Given what I witnessed outside its Ginza outlet, I'd probably prepare for a queue"** — of the crème brûlée, **"eat it immediately"**; of the beef short rib, **"messy"**. MiddleClass.sg is structural: **"Since each sando is fried to order, it is best eaten soon after you get it."** On Base Gelato, Eatbook's **Isaiah De En Gan** is positive and measured, calling the Matchagato **"a popular option"** — and issues no rating at all.[1][2]

THE SCEPTIC · FOUR OPENINGS, ONE REVIEW BETWEEN THEM

Age.3 and O/Sio have not served a paying table; Hama-Sushi has not announced a date; Base Gelato has exactly one write-up, with no verdict attached, and a second that merely logs it as having **"quietly opened"**. **None of the four is halal-certified.** None takes a booking. Base Gelato's scarcity is not hype but a timetable — three days a week, seven hours a day, nowhere to sit, and a product that will not travel.

ION ORCHARD JOO CHIAT TANJONG PAGAR [1][2][3][4]

THE HONESTY LEDGER

Age.3 publishes no Singapore price; in Japan its sandos run ¥650–850. **O/Sio**'s 4 November date comes from food media, not the group. **Hama-Sushi** is carried here as a plan, not a date. **Base Gelato** last appeared in No. 128 and this is its second and final run.[1][3][4]

SOURCES 1 Eatbook (and its sister coverage), The Honeycombers and MiddleClass.sg, all read at source, for Age.3's format and its distinction from a katsu sando, the Fukuoka origin and December 2023 Ginza opening, the overseas outlets, the million-sandos figure, the 34 varieties, the ION unit number and mid-November window, the Japanese price band, the Ginza queue times and every quotation above. **No Singapore opening date, hours or prices have been published, none is invented, and no Singapore review exists because the shop has not opened.** 2 Eatbook, 9 October 2026, by Isaiah De En Gan, read at source, for Base Gelato's Creamier parentage, the address, the three-day week, all six items and their nett prices and both quoted assessments; The Ranting Panda, read at source, for the "quietly opened" logging. **No second full review exists; the write-up carries no rating and none is implied.** 3 Eatbook, read at source, for O/Sio's address, 4 November date, chef, dishes and the S$18.80 entry price; **the group's own Tokyo site, read at source, confirms the chef and the Marunouchi original but does not mention Singapore, so the opening date is food-media-sourced only.** 4 Coverage of Hama-Sushi's Pasir Ris plan, read through its indexed text because **SETHLUI returned 403**, including its own statement that no official opening date has been announced and the possible second outlet is unconfirmed. **Reddit refused this desk for the ninth consecutive issue and Burpple returned 403, so no social chatter is quoted from either; the Michelin Guide's Singapore pages returned an empty body, so no Michelin signal is reported. Halal status was checked for all four and none is certified. Every venue named here was cleared against the 88 barred names in ledgers/table-ledger.md before selection.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · THAILAND

Ten million Thais hold a death benefit priced in the surviving headcount

A funeral mutual pays fifty baht times everyone still alive. Deaths have exceeded births for five years, and in Udon Thani a three-contract payout has fallen from 200,000 baht to 58,000.

The Thai word is **ญาปนกิจสงเคราะห์** — *chapanakit songkhro*, "cremation-rite relief". The monthly debit on a villager's bank statement has its own name, **เงินสงเคราะห์ศพ**, *ngoen songkhro sop*: corpse-relief money. Under the **Funeral Welfare Act of 2002** a funeral association is a mutual, not an insurer. When a member dies, every surviving member is levied a small fixed sum, and the dead member's family receives that sum multiplied by the number of survivors.[1]

Read that sentence again as a financial instrument. The benefit is **denominated in other people**. There is no reserve, no mortality table, no actuarial valuation and no solvency floor; the statutory levy caps are tiny and fall as the pool grows — **100 baht** per death in an association of 2,500 or fewer, **20 baht** above ten thousand. So two things move against the member at once as a pool ages: the annual cost rises with the death rate, because you pay per death, and the benefit falls with the headcount, because the payout *is* the headcount.[1]

Thailand crossed the line that prices this instrument five years ago and has stayed across it. Civil registration recorded **416,574 births in 2025** — the lowest in seventy-five years and the second consecutive year under half a million — against **559,684 deaths**, the fifth straight year of more deaths than births. The register stood at just over **65.80 million** at the end of the year, down from 65,951,210 twelve months earlier.[2]

The ministry's own count is **4,874** public associations with about **seven million** members, plus **80** government-sector bodies carrying **3.5 million** more. Ten and a half million people — **one Thai in six** — hold a contract whose payout is a live function of the national headcount and whose price is a live function of the national death rate. That is not a metaphor for demographic decline. It is a derivative on it, sold to farmers.[3]

And it has repriced. A 2008 national survey counted **3,762** associations with **18.69 million** members — **4,968** members apiece. On the 2026 register the public associations average **1,436**. The two are different instruments and the comparison is this desk's arithmetic, but the direction is not in doubt: at a fifty-baht levy, an average pool that size implies a death benefit falling from roughly **248,000 baht to about 72,000** — while a funeral in Isan costs **50,000 to 150,000**, and sometimes approaches 300,000.[4][5]

> ***The benefit is denominated in other people. A pay-as-you-go pension bets there will be more young people later; a pay-per-death mutual makes the same bet, written backwards and settled every month by direct debit.***

In **Udon Thani**, the province at the centre of it, the deputy governor has verified **1,066 deceased members** whose families have not been paid, owed more than **120 million baht** — about **112,570 baht** each — and **1,709** members still paying in. Benefits were cut unilaterally to **20,000, 30,000 and 8,000 baht** by category, so a holder of all three who once received about **200,000** now receives **58,000**. Some members pay over **2,000 baht a month** across their contracts. The state old-age allowance is **600 to 1,000 baht a month**.[6]

SOURCES 1 Matichon, 19 February 2026, read at source, reporting the Ministry of Social Development and Human Security's permanent secretary, for the structure of the Funeral Welfare Act B.E. 2545 (2002), the per-death levy caps by association size, the joining fee and annual dues, and the registrar structure. 2 **Bangkok Biznews's report of the Bureau of Registration Administration's own civil-registration series, read at source**, for the 2025 births and deaths, the five-year series and the year-end population. **The Bureau's own statistics host could not be reached from this desk — a DNS failure and then a proxy error — so the series is read one remove from the registry that compiled it.** 3 Naewna, 5 February 2026 and 8 September 2026, read at source, for the 4,874 associations and seven million members, and for the 80 government-sector bodies with 3.5 million. **These do not reconcile with the ministry's own "3,839 operating" given on 19 February, a gap of 1,035; both figures are printed.** 4 Aweewan Mangmeechai, NIDA, *IJABER* 13(4) 2015, read at source, citing the 2008 National Statistical Office survey, for 3,762 associations and 18.69 million members. **The 2008 survey and the 2026 register are different instruments; every per-association and implied-benefit figure above is this desk's arithmetic on them and is directional, not like-for-like.** 5 Soonthon Faytee and colleagues, Khon Kaen University, *Journal of MCU Buddhist Review* 10(2), published 31 August 2026, read at source, for the cost of an Isan funeral. 6 Thai PBS, 16 and 17 June 2026, read at source, for the Udon Thani probe, the verified 1,066 unpaid deaths and 120 million baht, the 1,709 still paying, the three benefit categories and the monthly contribution figures. **The old-age allowance rates could not be confirmed on a current official page and are carried from secondary reporting, flagged.**

The largest single failure is at **Wapi Pathum**, in Maha Sarakham, where villagers petitioned the Department of Special Investigation in May 2025 over roughly **1,400 million baht** of unpaid benefits. The promise was **400,000 baht** a death, against **400 baht a month into each of two funds — 9,600 baht a year** from a rural household. In **2022** the association paid out **53 million baht** of more than **200 million** collected from about forty thousand members: a payout ratio of roughly **26.5 per cent**. Membership peaked near **45,000 during the pandemic in 2020**.[1]

That pandemic peak is the second mechanism, and it is the one nobody has written down. COVID did not bankrupt these associations by killing people. It bankrupted them by **selling to them**. A mutual whose benefit is shrinking has exactly one lever — recruit more headcount — and the only people who will join an ageing pool are old.[12]

The documents are explicit. A teachers' co-operative association in **Surat Thani** ran a special intake in **August 2023** raising the maximum joining age from **45 to 75**, with surcharges by age band and waiting periods of thirty, sixty and ninety days. Its own leaflet of **28 January 2026** raised the ceiling again, to **80**. At **3,470** members the net payout is **160,120 baht** — so a seventy-five-year-old could buy a claim on about **152,576 baht** for an entry cost of **1,450**. The terminal version is in Udon Thani, where associations now require surviving members to **find a replacement for each member who dies**.[234]

The third thing, and the real scandal, is a category error. Thailand treats a death benefit as a **social** activity when neighbours organise it and a **financial** one when a company does. So the 2002 Act hands a municipal mayor or a sub-district chief the power to license an institution with tens of thousands of members, and places the central registrar inside the **Department of Women's Affairs and Family Institution**. The country's largest de facto life assurer — 18.7 million members in 2008, against 20.5 million private life policies in the whole country in 2012 — has never been examined by a financial regulator. The state did not fail to regulate a financial sector. **It never conceded that one existed.**[15]

> ***"The factors that will cause dissolutions to fall like dominoes, one after another." — Assoc. Prof. Dr Achara Chalayanonawin, Dean of Social Administration, Thammasat University***

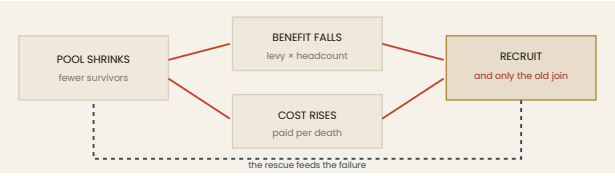
The precedent is American, and exact. The **Ancient Order of United Workmen**, founded at Meadville, Pennsylvania on **27 October 1868**, set the scheme in a charter amendment the following year: a one-dollar initiation fee bought a **$2,000** death benefit, and when a member died **every survivor paid a dollar**. By 1885 it was the largest fraternal benefit organisation in the United States. Substitute fifty baht for the dollar and 160,120 baht for the two thousand, and you have the Surat Thani leaflet of January 2026.[6]

The instructive case is the **Knights of Honor**, because it ran the repair Thailand is now contemplating. Judged unsustainable on flat assessments by the mid-1890s, it adopted an actuarially sound structure in **1895**, with a different rate for every age from 18 to 61. Membership peaked at **126,000 that year**, fell to **96,000 by 1897** and **90,335 by 1898**; its lodges went from about 2,600 in 1896 to **1,234 in 1910**; it disbanded in **1916**. A 28 per cent membership loss in three years, immediately after the fix. **The cure destroyed the patient.**[7]

SOURCES 1 Thai Post, 29 May 2025, and Thai PBS, 28 April 2026, both read at source, for the Wapi Pathum petition, the 1,400 million baht figure, the 400,000-baht promise and the 400-baht monthly contributions into each of two funds, the 2022 collection and payout, and the membership peak and decline. **The 26.5 per cent payout ratio and the 9,600-baht annual figure are this desk's arithmetic on those published numbers.** 2 **The Surat Thani teachers' co-operative funeral association's own leaflets of 2023 and 28 January 2026, both downloaded and read at source**, for the membership counts, the net payout calculation, the age ceilings of 75 and then 80, the age-banded surcharges and the waiting periods. **The 1,450-baht entry cost against a 152,576-baht claim is this desk's arithmetic on the association's own published figures.** 3 Dailynews, 7 September 2023, read at source, for the national teachers' scheme, its membership, its one-baht-per-member levy and the raised joining age. **Those figures are from 2023 and could not be updated; the scheme's own host returned HTTP 500.** 4 Thai PBS, 16 and 17 June 2026, read at source, for the replacement-recruitment requirement and the January recruitment drive and its takings. 5 Aweewan Mangmeechai, NIDA, *IJABER* 13(4) 2015, read at source, for the 2008 membership against the 2012 life-policy count and for the registrar structure. 6 The documented history of the Ancient Order of United Workmen — its founding date and place, founder, the 1869 charter amendment, the dollar levy and $2,000 benefit, and the 1885 and 1895 membership figures. 7 The documented history of the Knights of Honor — the certificate denominations, the mid-1890s judgement, the 1895 age-rated restructuring and every membership and lodge figure through its 1916 dissolution. **Both histories are secondary-sourced encyclopaedic records rather than primary archives, and are presented as precedent rather than as reporting.**

Where the analogy breaks is where it gets frightening. The American societies failed in a young, fast-growing country: their problem was pricing, and there were always more young men to charge correctly. Thailand's pricing flaw is identical and its denominator is **shrinking**, so an adequate rate on a contracting pool is a premium no young Thai will pay. The American fraternalist who left for age-graded rates could buy commercial life insurance, and millions did; no insurer will write a policy on a seventy-five-year-old Isan farmer for 1,450 baht. And the New Deal eventually replaced the function — where Thailand's state alternative is a **3,000-baht** funeral grant that in September 2024 required a cabinet allocation of **416,496,000 baht** to clear arrears owed to **138,832** people.[1]

The reform now being argued for is the 1899 mortality table and the 1910 Mobile bill in Thai. **Assoc. Prof. Dr Achara Chalayanonawin**, Dean of the Faculty of Social Administration at Thammasat University, wants an independent regulator on the insurance commission's model, with reserve standards, performance indicators and public ratings — she invokes A and AA grades — plus local networks of associations that police each other. She notes some associations hold no reserve at all for a surge of deaths, and that the two supervisory systems work **"แบบต่างคนต่างทำ (Silo)"** — each doing its own thing — because local government answers to Interior and the associations answer to Social Development. She is right, and the Knights of Honor is what being right looked like.[2]



The loop: a pay-per-death mutual whose payout is the surviving headcount can only be rescued by recruitment, and only the old will enrol. A *Meridian* original, drawn from the mechanism described in the Funeral Welfare Act and the associations' own order forms.

The sceptic's case is strong and must be printed. The ministry's permanent secretary, **Kantapong Rangsisawang**, said on 19 February that there is **"no nationwide dissolution… only 10 associations have been cancelled"** in eleven months, out of **3,839** operating — **0.26 per cent** — against roughly a thousand dissolved since 1974, about nineteen a year. **On the state's own numbers, 2026 is quieter than the long-run average.** He also insists on the legal nature of the thing: it is **"not saving, not a deposit, and not life insurance"**. And the field's own literature concluded in 2015 that these associations **"represent a sustainable way"** to cover funeral costs, with interviewees describing membership as **"a kind of donation"**.[3][4]

> ***"It is not saving, not a deposit, and not life insurance." The association's own leaflet calls it ngoen om — savings — and "the last gift for the one you love".***

The answer is that the fraud and the mathematics are not alternatives: the sums are what make the fraud invisible, and then unavoidable. A member watching a benefit fall 71 per cent for structural reasons cannot tell that from a committee stealing, and a committee facing a structural shortfall has every incentive to sign a thousand members in a month. But the dissolution count does not yet support "systemic collapse", and this desk says so.[3]

So here is the test, dated. The thesis fails if, at **31 December 2027**, gazetted dissolutions for 2026 and 2027 total fewer than **forty**, published membership is still at or above **seven million**, and no amendment imposing reserve requirements has reached cabinet. This desk's call, logged: **one is approved by the end of 2027.**[5]

What makes it worth attention from Singapore is not Thailand. Every ageing country has written the same promise — that there will be more people later — and most hide it inside a government balance sheet where nobody watches it reprice. Thailand wrote it on a leaflet, in baht, and settles it on the last day of every month.

SOURCES 1 Thai PBS, read at source, for the 3,000-baht funeral grant, the cabinet allocation of 416,496,000 baht in September 2024 and the 138,832 people in arrears as at 31 July — **the two multiply out exactly**; Mangmeechai (2015) for the earlier 2,000-baht version and the 169,720 unpaid in 2012–13. 2 Thai Post and Dailynews, both 21 February 2026, read at source, for Assoc. Prof. Dr Achara Chalayanonawin's quoted remarks, her reform proposals, the absence of reserves at some associations and the "silo" description of the two supervisory systems. 3 Matichon, 19 February 2026, read at source, for the permanent secretary's quoted statements, the ten dissolutions and the 3,839 operating; Dailynews, 20 February 2026, for the thousand dissolved since 1974, from which the long-run average is this desk's own calculation. 4 Dailynews, 20 February 2026, read at source, for the provincial bank directors' statements; Mangmeechai, *IJABER* 13(4) 2015, read at source, for the sustainability conclusion and the interviewees' characterisation. 5 **The falsification test and the prediction are this desk's own, logged with their check-by date in the predictions ledger. NEGATIVE CHECK, run explicitly: six search formulations, including a site-restricted one, found no feature, news story or explainer on Thailand's funeral welfare associations from the New York Times, BBC, Reuters, the Financial Times, the Guardian, the Economist, the Wall Street Journal or Bloomberg.**

THE LAST WORD

Who can check it

Today's book kept arriving at the same question, and it was never "is this true?" It was "who could tell?" Iran says it hit seven ships and names none of them; US Central Command says no vessel struck a mine; and the body that counts the attacks admits it is "struggling to accurately report true number of attacks" because owners will not report them (p3). A Homeland Security order binding every federal agency reached the Federal Register as scanned images, so its deadlines cannot be read by the people it binds (p7).

It runs all the way down the book. A statute twelve years old that has never produced a fine, against a cost estimate of S$3.2bn and a ceiling of S$2m (p5). A pair of glasses whose maker publishes no brightness figure, so the number everyone quotes comes from a sponsored post (p9). A laboratory that quietly revised its own benchmark table upward five days after the internet started citing it (p8). A sofa trade with no published moisture content, no published foam density and a leather "grade" its largest maker says is not a quality ranking (p6). A four-minute exercise trial whose two groups did not start level (p18). Even the good news is unverifiable: a watch priced identically to the watch it copies, which you can only know by opening two pages of the same website.

The closing essay is the pure case. Ten and a half million Thais hold a contract that pays fifty baht times everyone still alive, written by a ministry for families, licensed by village headmen, and never once examined by a financial regulator (p21). Nobody lied. Nobody was asked. The information asymmetry was not a flaw in the product — it was the product, and the sums has started settling it on the last day of every month.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 141 · 23 October 2026

SOURCES A note on method. This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: NEA's own four dated haze advisories and haze.gov.sg; the Federal Register notice 91 FR 66346 via govinfo.gov, and the EDGAR company and full-text searches run directly by this desk; the UK Treasury's counterpart, the US Treasury's own daily par-yield file; Press TV's publication of the IRGC statement; WHO AFRO's news release and its weekly situation report 23; Africa CDC's own release; *JAMA Pediatrics*, *Frontiers in Child and Adolescent Psychiatry*, *PLOS ONE*, *Clinical Neuropsychiatry* and *Sleep and Breathing*; Reflection AI's model card and the three independent quantisation cards, with every file size taken from repository blob metadata; H. Moser's two product pages; Box Office Mojo and Rotten Tomatoes; Hancock & Moore's own leather glossary and Natuzzi's Form 20-F from EDGAR; the makers' own store pages for every ultralight price and weight; the Meteorological Service Singapore and the Canadian Conservation Institute; and, for The Diary, the venue's or organiser's own page for every single row. Hosts that refused this desk, and are therefore quoted nowhere in this issue: Reuters, the BBC, the Associated Press, the Guardian, Sky News, CNBC, The Verge, Forbes, Variety, Hodinkee, WatchUSeek, Channel NewsAsia, The Straits Times, SETHLUI, Time Out Singapore, Burpple, Ticketmaster Singapore and Australia, Houzz, Vitra, Karimoku, Dutchware, the Pacific Crest Trail Association, EnterpriseSG, IMDA, SGX, the Bangkok Post and Mahidol's population institute. Reddit refused for the ninth consecutive issue, on every route including eleven mirrors. Where a figure could not be read at its own publisher it is flagged in that desk's sources line; where it could not be verified at all it was held or dropped rather than printed. One maker's page served text imitating an instruction to an automated reader; it was identified as page content and ignored.